

Characterizing Canadian Out-of-district Political Donations from 2015 to 2024*

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Federal political representation in Canada is geographical: one Member of Parliament (MP) represents one electoral district. Despite this representational structure, Canadians can legally donate to a host of political entities, regardless of proximity. Using a public dataset from Elections Canada’s Open Data on Contributions matched with census data from Statistics Canada, we characterize broad patterns in Canadian out-of-district donation from 2015 to 2024. We find that out-of-district donations form a persistent share of donor-sourced funding to both candidates and district associations, averaging 40% across time, election periods, and party lines. While relatively constant through time, the propensity for out-of-district donation varies substantially – and predictably – across districts, beyond what spatial proximity alone would predict. Districts with higher population density, median household income, educational attainment, and visible minority proportions see higher rates of out-of-district giving, the same traits that predict donor prevalence generally in Canada. Despite their frequency, out-of-district donations in Canada remain largely regionalized; nearly half of donations that leave their district are received by a political entity in a neighbouring one, and few cross provincial lines. These and other findings provide a helpful characterization of this largely undocumented facet of Canadian political financing, as well as help to inform further research on effective representation in Canada and other nations with similar representational structures.

Keywords: Canadian politics; out-of-district donations; surrogate representation; political participation; political geography

*Code and data are available at: <https://github.com/bennypk1/geolocating-political-donations>. We thank Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council of Canada (NSERC) Alliance Grant (ALLRP 599949 - 24) and Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council (SSHRC) Partnership Grant (895-2025-1002) for financial support. Corresponding author: rohan.alexander@utoronto.ca.

1 Introduction

In Canada, federal representation is structurally geographical. Citizens are grouped into a few hundred electoral districts based on where they live, each represented by a single Member of Parliament (MP). Despite this, many citizens seek representation beyond their district’s boundaries ([Mansbridge 2003](#)), possibly driven by motivations including ideological alignment and partisan loyalty. This “surrogate” representation can manifest itself in many ways, but is primarily exercised through financial contributions (i.e. donations), to political entities that represent districts other than their own. Out-of-district donations are not always representationally motivated, however. A citizen may donate as a favour to a friend, or to “fit in” with their social circles ([Gimpel et al. 2006](#); [Garnett et al. 2022](#)). Given that donations are the source of the majority of funds to electoral campaigns and district associations in North America ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#); [Garnett 2024](#); [Elections Canada 2026f](#)), documenting patterns of giving is important for understanding how political influence is distributed across the electorate. While Canadian research exists documenting the extent of and patterns in donations generally (e.g. [Besco and Tolley 2022](#); [Tolley et al. 2022](#); [Garnett 2024](#)), comparatively little attention has been given to out-of-district donations.

Existing research on out-of-district federal contributions in the U.S., which also uses a geographically-based representational structure, documents substantial rates of out-of-district donation. Both congressional and senatorial candidates presently source between 50 and 70 percent of their campaign funding from outside their district, a proportion that has dramatically increased over the start of the 21st century ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#); [Bednar and Gerber 2011](#); [Sievert and Mathiasen 2023](#)). Incumbent representatives also receive around half of their donations from out-of-district, which meaningfully influences their roll-call behaviour ([Peoples and Gortari 2008](#); [Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022](#)). These donations are thought to be primarily motivated by partisan gain, evidenced, for example, by increased donations to districts with close races ([Gimpel et al. 2008](#); [Jacobs and Imboywa 2024](#)). Both major parties primarily source local funding from a single small group of highly influential and socio-demographically similar districts ([Gimpel et al. 2006](#)).

In this paper, we document the extent of out-of-district donations in Canada, and identify spatio-temporal trends in Canadian out-of-district donation rates. To carry out our analysis, we leverage a database containing all contributions received by federal political entities from 2015 to 2024, made publicly accessible by Elections Canada. This dataset was augmented by situating donors in space, and matching donations to their socio-demographic environment using the 2021 Census, allowing us to better understand which factors correlate with out-of-district donation rates. We find that out-of-district donations form a persistent share of

donor-sourced funding to both electoral candidates and district associations, averaging 40% across time, election periods, and party lines. This invariability does not extend to space, however: the propensity for out-of-district donation changes substantially — and predictably — from district to district. Donations originating from densely populated, high-income, and well-educated districts are more likely to leave their district of origin, echoing predictors of out-of-district giving established in the U.S. Notably, the visible minority proportion of a donor’s district is the strongest socio-demographic predictor we identify. This finding departs from the ethnic profile historically associated with “donor districts” in the U.S. (Gimpel et al. 2008; Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022), but aligns with recent Canadian research linking minority ethnic communities to higher rates of political participation and out-of-district giving (Garnett et al. 2022; Besco and Tolley 2022). Despite the considerable presence of out-of-district donations during our study period, out-of-district giving remains a regionalized phenomenon: nearly half of all donations that leave their district of origin are addressed to political entities in a neighbouring one, and few ever cross a provincial boundary, limiting their potential influence on geographically-based representation. Though we do not formally test the representational impacts of out-of-district donations, their detailed characterization presented here helps inform further research on political financing and effective representation in Canada.

2 Background

2.1 Out-of-District Donations as a Form of Surrogate Representation

In Westminster-style parliamentary democracies including Canada, federal representation is fundamentally geographical: a Member of Parliament (MP) is a representative of everyone who lives within the boundaries of their riding. By voting during a general election, the citizens of a given electoral district increase the likelihood that their incumbent MP votes, acts, looks, and thinks how they want them to. Provided that (1) the division of people into ridings efficiently clusters like-minded Canadians, and (2) each Canadian participates equally (for example, through their one vote), we should expect a high degree of congruence between what a legislator does, and what their constituents want.

Beyond voting, individual citizens can increase their local representation by volunteering at a local district association, advocating for their preferred party online, or financially supporting a candidate’s campaign (Bednar and Gerber 2011; Baker 2016; Garnett 2024). Since these necessitate more resources (e.g. time, effort, or money), indicate greater political interest, and often have larger impacts on electoral outcomes relative to voting, these constitute “higher forms” of political participation (Milbrath 1981).

Among these, donations stand out as a useful unit for understanding the motivations behind political participation and assessing whether higher forms of political participation distort the dyadic relationship between constituents and their MP. We discuss two reasons why. First, donations are spatiotemporally unconstrained, telling us exactly when and where citizens seek representation (Gimpel et al. 2008; Garnett 2024). While a voter can only seek representation within their district and during an election cycle, a donor can legally contribute to various political entities, whenever, and as often as they want, subject to annual and per-election limits (Gimpel et al. 2008; Elections Canada 2026a). Second, donations are the primary means by which individuals extend their representation beyond district borders. Enabled by modern digital communication, individuals are increasingly motivated to finance national parties, or non-local candidates, in an attempt to be represented on ideological, partisan, or identity-based grounds (Gimpel et al. 2008). For example, a Green party partisan may realize their local candidate will lose, and are content funding another Green candidate in a closer race somewhere else. Similarly, a Black candidate may appeal to Black donors across the country seeking identity-based representation. Given that individual donors are the largest source of campaign funding (Carmichael and Howe 2014; Garnett 2024), high rates of out-of-district donation are of particular concern, since they risk shifting the effective representational structure away from one-legislator-one-district and towards one-legislator-one-donor base.

2.2 Political Donations in the Canadian Context: What has been done

Limited accounts of out-of-district donation rates exist in the Canadian context. An analysis of co-ethnic affinity among donors and candidates found that the likelihood that a donor donates out-of-district is higher for ethnic minorities (50-70%) compared to donors of European origin (33%) (Besco and Tolley 2022). However, these proportions only describe candidate-bound donations, and only during the 2015 general election period. Below we present a review of Canadian research on donations in general, to contextualize our subsequent analysis. We note that this research has focused almost exclusively on donations to candidates during writ periods (i.e. election periods).

Much research has been done to determine the socio-demographic characteristics of donors and candidates in Canada. Most notably, analyses of candidate-bound donations during the 2015, 2019, and 2021 general elections found that donors are more likely to originate from older, wealthier, and better-educated districts (Carmichael and Howe 2014; Garnett 2024). The gender gap in giving has received particular attention, likely given the broader context of the established gender gap in political participation McMahon et al. (2023). From 2004 to 2015, overall federal donation amounts have increased, particularly in Western Canada,

and among Conservative political entities (McMahon and Wolfe 2015). However, contribution rates to candidates during the following three general elections (in 2015, 2019, and 2021) have since decreased (Garnett 2024), and the COVID-19 pandemic saw overall reduced political participation (McMahon et al. 2023).

Garnett et al. (2022) propose that donors in Canada donate for two reasons: political (i.e. for representational gain) and transactional (i.e. a favour for a friend, or a willingness to be seen). They find that political motivations for giving are more prevalent overall, but especially among older and affluent donors who contributed larger sums. Transactional donations were more likely at the local level, while political donations were more likely at the national level.

Canadian donors tend to donate more to candidates that they share aspects of their identity with. For instance, women donors are more likely to donate to women candidates (Tolley et al. 2022), and there are high rates of co-ethnic donation, particularly among South Asian donors (Besco and Tolley 2022). More generally, South Asian political participation appears to be particularly heightened in Canada, relative to other ethnocultural groups (Garnett 2024). Together with previous findings on donor motivation, these results suggest that out-of-district donors in Canada are predominantly socially motivated, seeking individual-based representation.

Some work has also been done assessing the impacts of large amounts of political donation on representation. Among incumbent legislators, voting behaviour is seemingly independent of the composition of their donor base (Peoples and Gortari 2008). However, Eagles (2004) found that local campaign donations during the 1993 and 1997 elections meaningfully affected the number of votes a candidate receives.

Finally, we describe some unique aspects of Canadian political engagement, and particularly those that distinguish Canada from the U.S., where the large majority of work on out-of-district donations has been done. Most notably, party loyalty in Canada is weak; it is estimated that only around 2% of Canadians are registered members of any political party (Garnett et al. 2022), compared with around 40% in the U.S. (USAFacts 2026). This has been attributed to many things, including the argument that Canada’s multi-party system de-emphasizes partisan membership (Carty 2002). This system also invites more ephemeral loyalties, based on specific policies or identities, and not broad-scope ideological affiliation. Many (historically) large parties in Canada were founded for specific reasons, for example the Bloc Québécois, Reform Party, and Green Party, which cater(ed) to a very specific audience. High rates of immigration may have increased emphasis on cultural and not political belonging (Carty 2002; Besco and Tolley 2022).

2.3 American Out-of-District Donations to U.S. House Representatives

In the U.S., Gimpel et al. (2008) examine out-of-district donations and their impacts on legislative representation, looking at individual out-of-district donations during four Congressional elections between 1994 and 2004. They propose the existence of “donor districts”; a small set of older, wealthy, well-educated, and urban districts wherein a large majority of out-of-district donations originate, destined to Republican and Democrat candidates alike (Gimpel et al. 2008). Notably, these socio-economic predictors of out-of-district donor output in the U.S. are the same as predictors of donor output generally in both the U.S. and Canada (Gimpel et al. 2006; Garnett 2024). Over this time period, they also observed an increase in the proportion of non-local donations received by the average candidate, from around 50% in 1994 to nearly 70% in 2004 (Gimpel et al. 2008). More recent studies suggest that this and similar trends have continued past 2004 (Bramlett et al. 2011; Baker 2016; Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022). Driven by the observation that the “closeness” of local races strongly predicted which districts received these non-local donations, Gimpel et al. (2008) argue that gaining a partisan advantage (and not seeking ideological or identity-based representation) is the primary motivation behind non-local donations.

Follow-up U.S. research has found that out-of-district campaign contributions affects the voting behaviour of Congressional representatives, thereby distorting the supposedly-dyadic relationship between a representative and their district. A study of the 2006-2010 Congressional elections revealed that the average House representative becomes less responsive to their constituencies’ ideological preferences with increased out-of-district public funding (Baker 2016). Canes-Wrone and Miller (2022) further explore the 2006-2016 Congressional elections to show that House voting behaviour is indeed associated with the preferences of their national donor base, contrasted against research finding that political action committees (U.S. equivalents to Canada’s district associations) do not affect roll call behaviour (Ansolabehere et al. 2003). Another study on senatorial elections emphasizes the rivalrous relationship between constituents and out-of-district donors, experimentally showing that constituents who learned about outside donation expected their senators to be less loyal to local interests (Nathan et al. 2025). More generally, longitudinal analyses of out-of-state (and therefore out-of-district donations) during Senate elections echo many House findings (Sievert and Mathiasen 2023; Jacobs and Imboywa 2024; Keena 2024).

3 Data and Methods

3.1 Data Overview

The data used in this paper was originally sourced from the Elections Canada Open Data on Contributions datasets([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). Since 2004, the *Canada Elections Act* has required that all contributions (monetary or otherwise) valued at over \$20 be recorded by the recipient and shared with the government ([Elections Canada 2026f](#)). The Elections Canada dataset on donations contains all donations made by individuals to registered federal political entities since 2004 ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). Additionally, donors who contributed over \$200 must have their full name and address (including their postal code) recorded ([Elections Canada 2026f](#)). For all contributions, Elections Canada also records the recipient’s name, affiliated district (if applicable), party (if applicable), entity (e.g. national party, candidate, etc.), and the date the contribution was received. The primary dataset used in this study is a cleaned version of Elections Canada’s, made available to us by the Investigative Journalism Foundation. Their cleaning process is described in Appendix [B.1](#).

To even be considered as out-of-district, a federal donation must be received by a political entity that is representationally tied to a specific district. For this reason, only donations received by candidates during election periods and district associations¹ (hereafter referred to as localized entities) can be considered in the study of out-of-district donations. Donations received by non-localized entities present in this dataset (parties or leadership contestants) cannot. Given their prevalence, however, we briefly compare these with localized entities in Section [3.2.1](#).

Every ten years, federal electoral district (FED) boundaries are redrawn to account for population changes that occurred within the decade ([Elections Canada 2025b](#)). To restrict our focus to a single, static set of FEDs, our analysis only includes contributions made during the 2013 representational order, effective between October 2, 2015 and April 22, 2024 ([Elections Canada 2025b](#)). This is the largest such order present in the dataset, capturing 61% of all recorded contributions since 2004, and spanning three general election periods (42nd, 43rd, and 44th). Donors were matched to their FEDs by their postal codes using Statistics Canada’s

¹Although nomination contestants and by-election candidates are also local political entities and were present in the data, these were not considered to simplify our analysis and discussion, since they only make up 0.7% of donations addressed to localized entities.

Postal Code Conversion Files² (PCCF), made available to us by the University of Toronto (Statistics Canada 2025). Donor FEDs were then compared with recipient FEDs to assess whether a donation was out-of-district. Donor location was not recorded for the majority of donations under \$200, and the small share that could be donor-geolocated were distributed very differently from the rest of the data. For these reasons, this study only considers donations above \$200, as was done in similar studies (Gimpel et al. 2008; Garnett 2024). These smaller donations are discussed further in Appendix D.

Donations were also situated within census dissemination areas (DA), allowing us to attribute socio-demographic characteristics to donation sources at a fine spatial grain. For each dissemination area, we identified its population, population density, median household income, mean age, proportion of the population with a post-secondary education, and proportions of various visible minority ethnicities. A full list of the ethnicities we tracked is available in Appendix C.2. These variables were chosen since they are significantly associated with the propensity to donate during an election (Gimpel et al. 2006, 2008; Garnett 2024). Further, ethnicities were disaggregated since previous Canadian research has found that some minority groups such as South Asians donate at much higher rates than others (Besco and Tolley 2022). We again used the PCCF to match donor postal codes to the DAs of the 2021 Census, and to group DAs into FEDs³ to deduce the same socio-demographic information at the district level. A detailed walkthrough of the full data pipeline, from the files available for download on Canadian government websites to the core datasets used for analysis can be found in Appendix B and Appendix C. All data cleaning, visualizations, and analyses were conducted using the R statistical software (R Core Team 2025).

3.2 Data Summaries

3.2.1 Situating Localized Donations

We first provide preliminary summaries of all contributions⁴ during our study period, to help situate further analysis of out-of-district donations. Table 1 breaks down donations by recipient type. National entities (parties and leadership contestants) received the majority (80.8%)

²Postal codes may straddle multiple FEDs. For this study, we created a deterministic spatial lookup table that resolves these cases using reasonable criteria. Donations whose postal codes could not be matched in this way were dropped. Our methodologies, and statistical assessments of their impacts are detailed further in Appendix C.1.

³Dissemination areas may straddle multiple FEDs. Appendix C.1 discusses how this was handled.

⁴Throughout this paper, the terms “contribution” and “donation” are used interchangeably and implicitly refer to contributions above \$200 that were successfully donor-geolocated, unless otherwise specified.

Table 1: Summaries of financial contributions to federal political entities over \$200 from 2015 to 2024, separated by entity. Only localized contributions (those addressed to candidates and district associations) are considered further in our study of out-of-district donations. Contributions received by nomination contestants are not shown, nor studied.

Political Entity	Type	Donation Count	Donation Amount (Thousands)	Share of Total Amount
Candidate	Localized	30,559	\$19,883	4.6%
District Association	Localized	108,619	\$63,354	14.6%
Leadership Contestant	National	47,873	\$32,451	7.5%
Party	National	618,609	\$319,056	73.4%

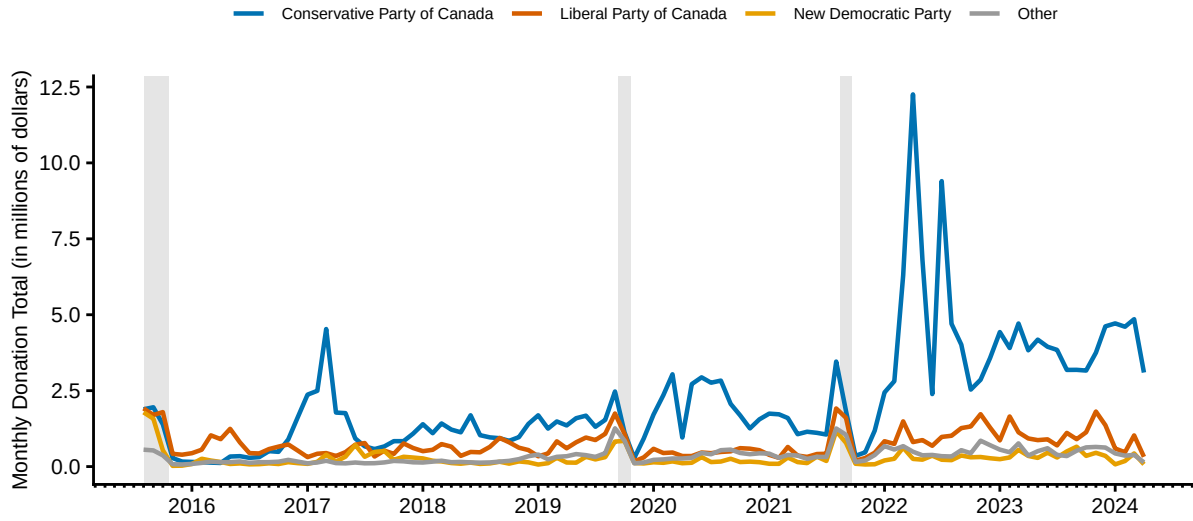
of contributions during our study period. Among donations addressed to localized entities, 24.3% are received by candidates, and 75.7% were received by district associations (EDAs)⁵. Proportions are similar when broken down by count instead of amount.

Figure 1 shows how contributions during our study period are distributed in time⁶. The six main peaks in donations to national entities correspond clearly to general election periods (peaks followed by grey shaded regions), and Conservative party leadership campaigns (peaks in the blue trend line). Donation rates generally increased over our study period, following the increasing trend observed from 2004 to 2015 by McMahon and Wolfe (2015) during the previous decade. This is particularly noticeable after the 2021 general election, driven primarily by increased donations to the Conservative party and (to a lesser extent) the Liberal party. By contrast, donation rates to localized entities were relatively constant across our study period, apart from large peaks during election periods, driven by both increases in donations to district associations, and the presence of donations to electoral candidates. We also observe a significant reduction in donation rates from the start of 2019 to mid-2021, which may partially be explained by the COVID-19 pandemic, agreeing with previous findings on reduced contribution rates during this period (McMahon et al. 2023). Additional comparisons between donations bound for national entities and those bound for localized entities are presented in Appendix F.

⁵In our dataset, candidates receive all of their donations during writ-periods. During these periods, they instead represent 48% of the total amount contributed to localized entities, with district associations making up the remaining 52% (Appendix F)

⁶For this visualization, donations dated in December of each year were redistributed across the other months of that year to address a clerical error in district association financing records.

A. National entities



B. Localized entities

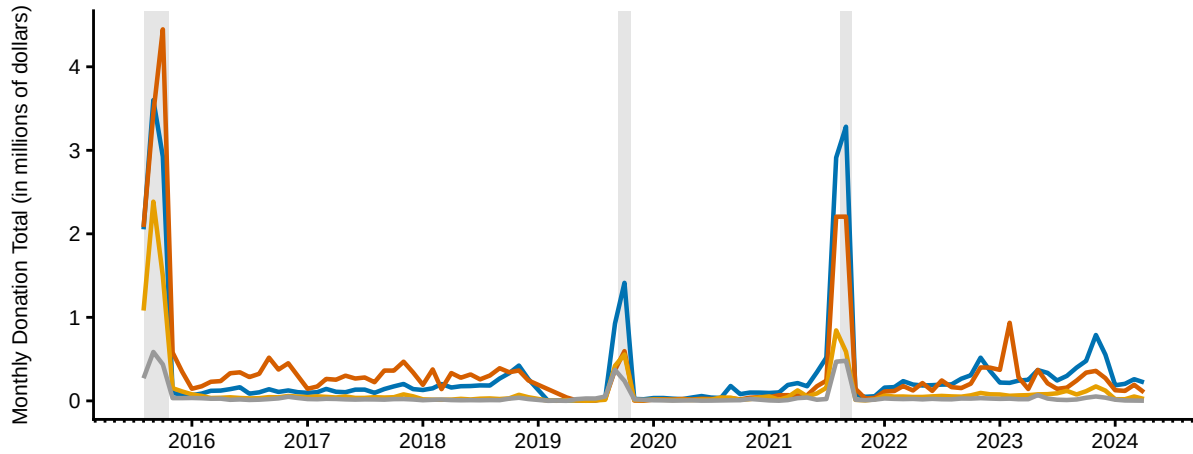


Figure 1: Timeline of financial contributions to federal political entities over \$200, from 2015 to 2024. (A) shows only contributions to national entities (parties and leadership contestants), and (B) shows only contributions to localized entities (candidates and district associations). Within each panel, trendlines are separated by the party of the recipient. Shaded vertical bars indicate the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general election periods respectively. Graphs were qualitatively similar when contributions under \$200 were included.

Table 2: Proportion of contributions over \$200 that were received by localized entities (candidates and district associations) outside the donor’s district, from 2015 to 2024. Raw and value-weighted proportions of out-of-district donations (OOD) are reported. Overall contribution counts and amount are also reported for reference. Contributions received by candidates outside general election cycles (by-elections) are not included in calculations.

Political Entity	Donation Count	Donation Amount (Thousands)	OOD Proportion	OOD Proportion (Amount Weighted)
Candidate	30,559	\$19,883	37.6%	40.2%
District Association	108,619	\$63,354	43.8%	47.8%

3.2.2 Trends in Out-of-District Donation Rates

In this section, we present data summaries describing when, to who, and where out-of-district contributions are more or less common. Table 2 displays the proportion of contributions above \$200 (raw and amount-weighted) that were sent out-of-district, for candidate- and EDA-bound donations. Overall, candidates received 37.6% of these donations from outside their district, and EDAs received 43.8%⁷. In both cases, these proportions increase when donations are weighed by their value, indicating that out-of-district donations are larger, on average, than their within-district counterparts. Table 3 and Figure 2 showcase how out-of-district funding rates change over time, for candidates and district associations respectively. Candidate out-of-district rates show a slight decreasing trend, from 39.5% in the 42nd general election in 2015 to around 35.4% in subsequent periods (Table 3). However, this may simply reflect the heightened absolute number of contributions garnered in 2015 compared to other periods. EDAs received roughly the same proportion of contributions above \$200 during the entire study period, including during writ periods (Figure 2)⁸.

Figure 3 displays the relationship between in- and out-of-district contribution amounts, for each electoral district present in our dataset. We display donations to candidates and district associations separately. In both cases, out-of-district contribution rates vary greatly from district to district⁹. Some Toronto metropolitan districts such as Toronto—St.Paul’s and University—Rosedale sent between 70% and 80% of their contributions to localized entities

⁷A comparison of the value distributions of in- and out-of-district donations is available in Appendix F.

⁸Roughly similar rates, and the same consistency through time, were observed when entities from individual parties were examined (Appendix F).

⁹The marginal distribution of out-of-district proportions across all districts is shown in Appendix F.

Table 3: Proportion of contributions to electoral candidates over \$200 that were out-of-district (OOD) over the three general election periods that occurred during our study period. Raw and value-weighted proportions are reported, along with the overall number of contributions (in- and out-of-district) for reference. Contributions received by candidates outside general election cycles (by-elections) are not included in calculations.

General Election	Donation Count	Donation Amount (Thousands)	OOD Proportion	OOD Proportion (Amount Weighted)
42nd general election	16,662	\$10,383	39.5%	41.9%
43rd general election	7,900	\$5,204	35.2%	39.1%
44th general election	5,997	\$4,296	35.6%	37.7%

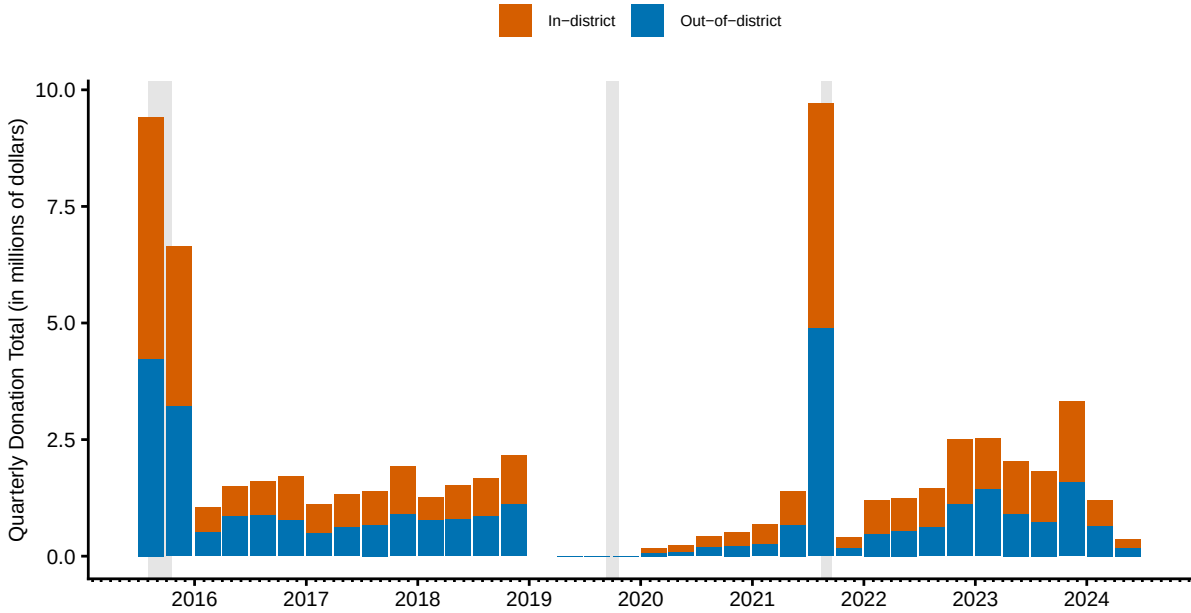


Figure 2: Timeseries of in- (red) and out-of-district (blue) financial contributions over \$200 addressed to district associations, from 2015 to 2024. Shaded vertical bars indicate the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general election periods respectively. Trend is similar when raw proportions are displayed instead of amount-weighted ones.

in other districts, while others such as Alberta’s Lethbridge and Ontario’s Niagara Falls only sent between 5% and 15% of their localized contribution sum to other districts. Many districts, especially for donations addressed to candidates, have extremely low out-of-district donation rates, as illustrated by the line of points near $y = 0$ in Figure 3. We also find that, at least among the few top districts by contribution amount, out-of-district propensity is not a simple function of urbanization¹⁰; Vancouver Granville in British Columbia and Brampton North are similarly metropolitan, but have vastly different out-of-district contribution rates to electoral candidates¹¹.

3.2.3 Characterizing Inter-District Funding Flows

Finally, we briefly describe some characteristics of the localized funding network formed by out-of-district donations. Figure 4 displays the relationship between the amount donated out-of-district and the amount received from out-of-district, for each district. For both entities, the majority of districts fall cleanly into two groups; those that send more than they receive (e.g. Trinity—St. Paul), and those that receive more than they send (e.g. Scarborough Centre).

Table 4 shows the proportion of contributions that are received by neighbouring districts, and by districts out-of-province, among all out-of-district contributions. These proportions offer a rough picture of how far the average out-of-district donation travels¹². For both entities, around 40% of out-of-district donations are sent to adjacent districts, while only around 12% reach other provinces. Out-of-district donations are overall closer to home for candidate-bound donations, echoing our findings in Table 2. Those out-of-province donations are visualized further in Figure 5. For donations to district associations, the total flux (sum of contributed amount received and sent) of a province strongly correlates with its population, and contribution rates are larger between two highly populated provinces. The network of interprovincial funding of candidates, however, has different primary edges, and overall contributions are more concentrated between B.C., Alberta, and Ontario. While we should expect reduced interprovincial contribution rates to candidates compared to EDAs (Table 4), certain differences

¹⁰Since districts vary enormously in size and shape depending on their population density, one might naturally expect that tightly-packed urban districts would have higher out-of-district contribution rates, simply due to the spatial nature of socio-political interest. In Appendix E, we simulate the out-of-district share for each district under this expectation, and find that district-level out-of-district proportions differ much more than what can be explained by the spatial arrangement of districts alone.

¹¹District-level differences in candidate-bound out-of-district contribution rates are even more pronounced when election periods are examined individually (Appendix F).

¹²A distribution of donation distances (measured from the centroid of donor’s dissemination area to the centroid of the recipient’s district) is displayed in Appendix E.

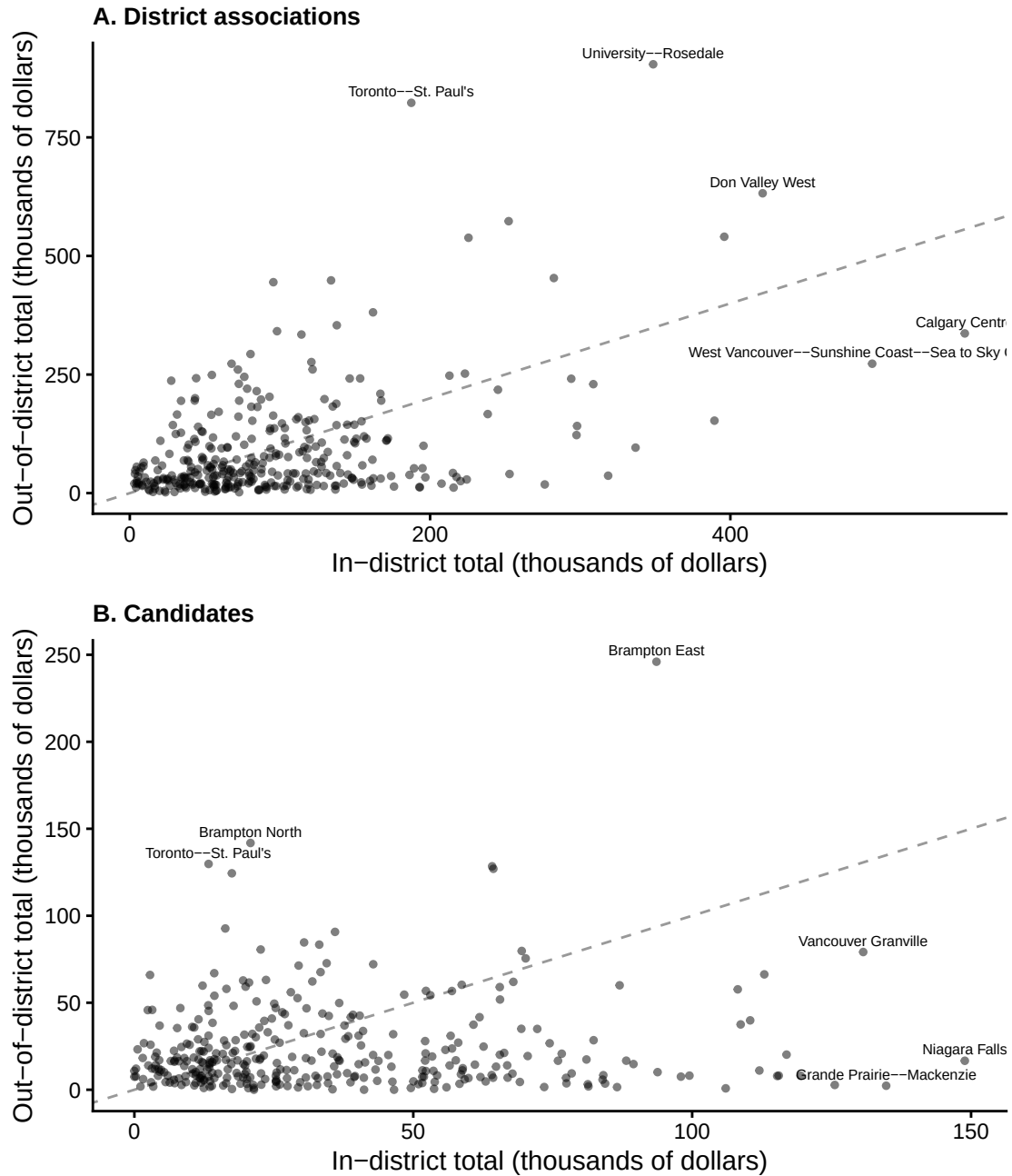


Figure 3: Relationship between the sum of contributions over \$200 donated in- v.s. out-of-district, for each district during the 2013 representational order (effective between 2015 and 2024). (A) shows this relationship for donations to EDAs, and (B) shows this for donations to candidates. Points represent individual districts. The grey dashed line is 1:1. The top 3 districts by amount contributed in- and out-of-district respectively are labelled with their names. Graphs are similar when counts are displayed instead of amounts. (A) is similar when only donations sent during writ periods are considered, and (B) is similar when specific election cycles are considered.

Table 4: Proportion of out-of-district contributions over \$200 that were sent to adjacent districts, and out-of-province during our study period. Raw and value-weighted proportions are reported, along with the overall number of contributions for reference. Contributions received by candidates outside general election cycles (by-elections) are not included in calculations.

Received by	Sent to	By count	By amount
Candidate	Adjacent district	43.3%	44.1%
Candidate	Out-of-province	10.6%	9.7%
District association	Adjacent district	37.1%	36.0%
District association	Out-of-province	14.7%	14.4%

in the candidate network such as Ontario and B.C. concentrating their outflow to Alberta, represent genuine differences in interprovincial funding regimes between these entities.

3.3 Out-of-District-Propensity Models

3.3.1 Individual-Level Model

We used a logistic regression model to explore how the likelihood of out-of-district donation varies across different transaction characteristics and donor socio-demographic environments, for individual donations. Our outcome variable is binary: whether or not a donation was sent out-of-district¹³.

The predictors in our model are: the type of recipient (candidate or district association), their political party, and the monetary value of the donation. Following Garnett (2024), we also considered the following characteristics of the donor’s environment: province (grouped into regions), mean age, median household income, the share of the population with a post-secondary degree, and the share of the population that is a visible minority. These predictors are associated with out-of-district donation in the U.S. (Gimpel et al. 2006, 2008). These environmental characteristics were assigned to donations based on their donor’s dissemination area.

We also included the population density of the donor’s district, for two reasons. First, out-of-district donors are more likely to come from urban (and therefore more densely populated)

¹³This model was fit on both donations to EDAs and candidates combined. Models fit on each localized entity separately had similar coefficient magnitudes, signs and significances (except that age had a slightly significant negative effect for registered associations).

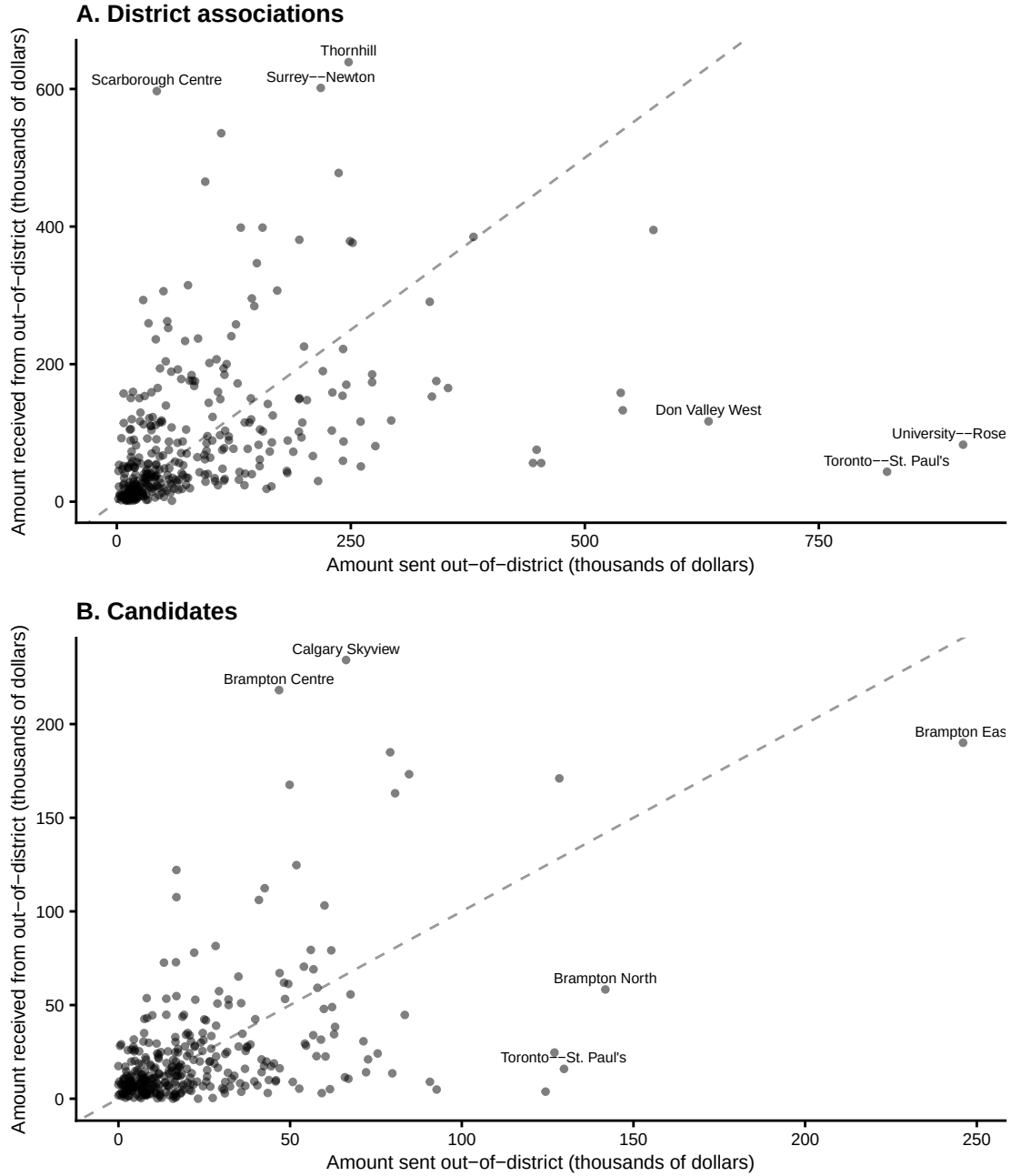
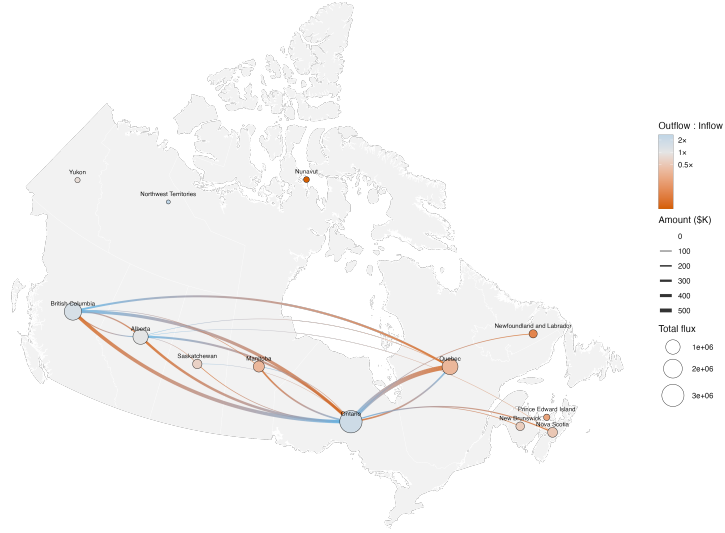


Figure 4: Relationship between the sum of contributions over \$200 sent out-of-district v.s. received from out-of-district, for each district during the 2013 representational order (effective between 2015 and 2024). (A) shows this relationship for donations to EDAs, and (B) shows this for donations to candidates. Points represent individual districts. The grey dashed line is 1:1. The top 3 districts by amount sent and received respectively are labelled with their names. Graphs are similar when counts are displayed instead of amounts. (A) is similar when only donations sent during writ periods are considered, and (B) is similar when specific election cycles are considered.

A. District associations



B. Candidates



Figure 5: Interprovincial funding flows for contributions over \$200 during the 2013 representational order (effective between 2015 and 2024). (A) shows flows for donations to EDAs, and (B) shows flows for donations to candidates. Networks were similar when counts were displayed instead of amounts. Node size reflects total interprovincial flux (amount sent + amount received), and edges are weighted by transfer amount. Provinces with red-coloured nodes receive more contributions than they send, and vice-versa for blue nodes. Edges are coloured on a gradient from blue (sending province) to red (receiving province) to mark direction. Candidate networks for individual writ-periods were similar to their aggregate displayed here.

districts in the U.S. (Gimpel et al. 2008). Second, population density serves as a relatively good proxy for how spatially clustered a district is, since Canadian districts are designed to have similar population sizes (Elections Canada 2025b). Out-of-district donation rates are likely naturally higher in smaller districts, since donors are more likely to interact with individuals, businesses, or politicians close by that happen to be located in a different district. Population density was transformed in the model by applying a square root, allowing us to interpret the metric as the inverse of the average distance between people, which captures this distance effect more faithfully¹⁴.

The resulting model is:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{logit}(p_i) = & \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Election}_i + \beta_2 \text{Candidate}_i + \sum_{j=3}^5 \beta_j \text{Party}_{ji} + \beta_6 \text{Amount}_i \\ & + \sum_{k=7}^{11} \beta_k \text{Region}_{ki} + \beta_{12} \text{Age}_i + \beta_{13} \text{Income}_i + \beta_{14} \text{Education}_i + \beta_{15} \text{VisMin}_i \\ & + \beta_{16} \text{Density}_i \end{aligned}$$

where:

- p_i is the probability that donation i was an out-of-district donation.
- Election_i indicates whether donation i occurred during a general election period.
- Candidate_i indicates whether donation i was addressed to a Candidate (baseline is EDA).
- Party_{ji} indicates which party (among Liberal, N.D.P, or Other, with baseline being Conservative) the recipient is associated with.
- Amount_i is the monetary value of donation i .
- Region_{ki} indicates which region (among Atlantic Canada, B.C., Prairies, Quebec, Territories, with baseline being Ontario) the donor is located.
- Age_i is the average age of residents in the donor's dissemination area.
- Income_i is the median household income in the donor's dissemination area.
- PostSec_i is the proportion of residents in the donor's home district holding a post-secondary qualification.
- VisMin_i is the proportion of residents in the donor's home district who identify as a visible minority.

¹⁴The observed spatial variation in out-of-district propensity is not well-explained by the spatial arrangement of districts alone (see Appendix E), however it remains an important consideration.

- Density_i is the population density (persons per km^2) of the donor's home district. As mentioned in-text, the model was fit using the squared root of this variable.

3.3.2 District-Level Model

Inspired by the large variation in out-of-district giving between districts observed in Figure 3, we fit a second regression model to explore which socio-demographic features were associated with higher rates of out-of-district donation, aggregated at the district level. Our outcome variable in this case was the share of all¹⁵ contributions¹⁶ sent out-of-district during our entire study period, for each district. Given that this outcome is a proportion, we used beta regression¹⁷.

The covariates included in this model were the same environment variables chosen for the individual-level model, aggregated at the district level.

The resulting model is:

$$\begin{aligned}
 p_i &\sim \text{Beta}(\mu_i, \phi) \\
 \text{logit}(\mu_i) &= \beta_0 + \beta_1 \text{Amount}_i + \sum_{j=2}^6 \beta_j \text{Region}_{ji} + \beta_7 \text{Age}_i \\
 &\quad + \beta_8 \text{Income}_i + \beta_9 \text{Education}_i + \beta_{10} \text{VisMin}_i \\
 &\quad + \beta_{11} \text{Density}_i
 \end{aligned}$$

where:

- p_i is the proportion of the total contributed amount that was sent out-of-district by donors in district i .
- μ_i is the mean of the beta distribution for district i , and ϕ is the common precision parameter.
- Amount_i is the total amount contributed by donors in district i .
- Region_{ji} are indicators for the donor region of district i .

¹⁵This model was fit on both donations to EDAs and candidates combined. A model fit on only EDAs separately had similar coefficient magnitudes, and the same signs and significances. A model fit on only candidates was not investigated due to data sparsity and the presence of singularities in the response.

¹⁶We observed high covariance ($R^2 = .93$) between the proportion of out-of-district donations and the share of total contributed amount that left the district, for both candidates and EDAs. Therefore, results would have been similar for a count-based outcome.

¹⁷Although our unit of analysis for this model is spatial, our fitted model did not show signs of spatial autocorrelation.

- Age_i is the mean age of residents in district i .
- Income_i is the median household income in district i .
- Education_i is the proportion of residents in district i holding a post-secondary qualification.
- VisMin_i is the proportion of residents in district i who identify as a visible minority.
- Density_i is the population density (persons per km^2) of district i . As mentioned in-text, the model was fit using the squared root of this variable.

4 Results

Here we present the results from our out-of-district propensity models. We note that many of our key findings are best understood as data summaries and visualizations, which are presented in Section 3.2. Section 3.2.1 provides context for how the localized contributions considered in our study fit into the broader scope of financial contributions in general. Section 3.2.2 provides spatio-temporal summaries of out-of-district propensity (which were used to inform the model discussed here). Section 3.2.3 briefly characterizes the funding network formed by out-of-district donations. Both summary-based and model-based findings are considered together in the Discussion section of this paper.

Regression results from the individual- and district-level models are presented in Table 5 and Table 6 respectively. Figure 6 and Figure 7 provide a visualization of coefficient signs, magnitudes, and significances. For both models, exponentiating the coefficients yields a more interpretable value, the odds ratio. For the individual (i.e. the logistic) regression model, an odds ratio above one for a categorical variable (e.g. recipient belonging to the Liberal Party) indicates that, holding all else constant, donations of that category have increased odds of being out-of-district, relative to the baseline category (e.g. recipient belonging to the Conservative party). For the district level (i.e. the beta) regression model, an odds ratio above one for a categorical variable (e.g. recipient belonging to the Liberal Party) indicates that, holding all else constant, the exact ratio of out- vs. in-district contributions increases. Odds ratios less than one and continuous variables (e.g. median household income) are interpreted accordingly.

Individual donations are less likely to reach out-of-district when they are bound for candidates instead of district associations (EDAs), and Liberal recipients instead of Conservative recipients. The contribution likelihoods of Conservative and N.D.P recipients were not meaningfully different. Larger donations were more likely to leave the district compared to smaller ones, helping to explain why amount-weighted proportions in our data summaries were consistently larger. Donations originating from all regions were less likely to reach out-of-district compared

to Ontario, with the exception of Quebec, whose donors have nearly 1.5 times the odds to donate out-of-district, holding all else constant. Donations originating in the Territories were especially unlikely to travel outside their district, with nearly one-eighth the baseline Ontario odds. Turning to the donor’s socio-demographic environment, regions with higher population densities, post-secondary education rates, median household incomes, and visible minority proportions¹⁸ all favoured out-of-district donation. However, the average age did not significantly impact out-of-district chances in the presence of other socio-demographic variables¹⁹.

At the district level, we modelled the ratio of out- to in-district contribution sums. Similarly to the individual models, districts with higher population densities, post-secondary education rates, median household incomes, and visible minority proportions were more likely to allocate more of their contributions to political entities in other districts rather than their own. The average age of a district was, similarly, insignificant in the presence of other socio-demographic variables. The regions with the largest coefficients by magnitude in the individual model (Quebec and the Territories) also had significant effects on the ratio of out- to in-district donation relative to Ontario, and had the same signs. However, Atlantic Canada, British Columbia, and the Prairies had out- to in-district donation ratios that were no different than Ontario in the presence of other variables²⁰. While donations are more likely to travel out-of-district when they are larger, the out- to in-district ratio of donations is smaller when more is donated overall. This tells us that, while bigger cheques are more likely to be received in a separate district than smaller ones, districts that raise more overall tend to do so by attracting a larger number of smaller, in-district donations rather than a smaller number of large, out-of-district donations.

The seven variables used in our district-level model were able to explain a large amount of the variance in the ratio of out- to in-district donation ($pseudoR^2 = 0.67$). The same model fit on only population density also achieved a relatively good fit ($pseudoR^2 = 0.45$), however other variables, and especially socio-demographic ones such as educational attainment and visible minority proportion, improved the model’s explanatory power well past what population density alone could offer.

¹⁸This effect was observed even when donations from the four Brampton constituencies were removed, since the data summaries showed that these clearly had very high influence on the model fit. A similar check was performed on the district-level model. When ethnicities were disaggregated, this effect was only observed for the proportion of South Asian, Black, and Chinese residents, not all minorities recorded in the Census (see Appendix C.2).

¹⁹Average age was significant in individual and district-level models where it, along with population density, were the only socio-demographic predictors. This tells us that its effect is mostly explained by other factors, such as income or educational attainment.

²⁰These findings held true when regions were disaggregated into individual provinces.

Table 5: Results from a logistic regression model where the outcome is whether or not an individual donation was sent out-of-district. Reference entity is the district association, reference party is the Conservative Party, reference region is Ontario.

Term	Coefficient	Odds Ratio	P-Value
(Intercept)	-2.788	0.062	<2e-16
Candidates	-0.149	0.862	<2e-16
Liberal	0.310	1.363	<2e-16
N.D.P	0.001	1.001	0.96
Other	0.352	1.422	<2e-16
Amount	0.000	1.000	<2e-16
Atlantic Canada	-0.219	0.804	2.26e-16
British Columbia	-0.444	0.642	<2e-16
Prairies	-0.285	0.752	<2e-16
Quebec	0.371	1.449	<2e-16
Territories	-2.008	0.134	<2e-16
Age	-0.001	0.999	0.192
Income	0.000	1.000	<2e-16
Education	1.862	6.439	<2e-16
Visible Minority	2.230	9.299	<2e-16
Population Density (sqrt)	0.003	1.003	<2e-16

Table 6: Results from a beta regression model where the outcome is the out-of-district share of the sum of contributions over \$200 originating from an individual district during our study period. Reference entity is the district association, reference party is the Conservative Party, reference region is Ontario.

Term	Coefficient	Odds Ratio	P-Value
(Intercept)	-4.239	0.014	3.42e-07
Amount	-0.000	1.000	0.0305
Atlantic Canada	0.234	1.263	0.0945
British Columbia	-0.143	0.867	0.192
Prairies	-0.049	0.952	0.644
Quebec	0.560	1.751	9.4e-07
Territories	-1.370	0.254	0.00416
Age	0.016	1.016	0.332
Income	0.000	1.000	1.22e-07
Education	1.601	4.958	0.0129
Visible Minority	1.918	6.805	1.2e-15
Population Density (sqrt)	0.013	1.013	7.87e-08

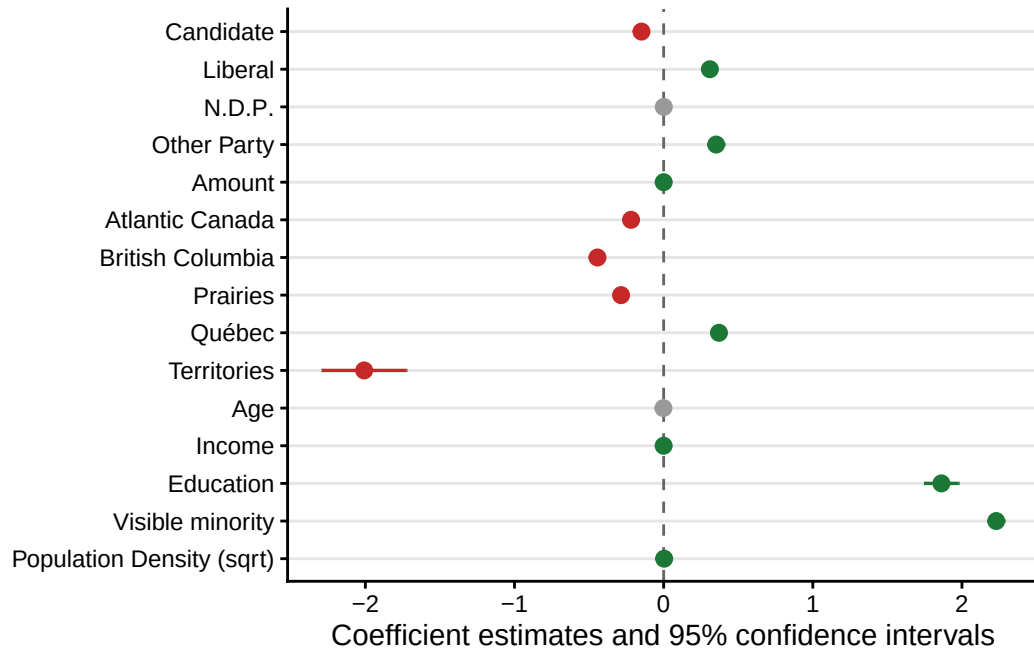


Figure 6: Coefficient estimates and 95% confidence intervals from a logistic regression model where the outcome is whether or not an individual donation was sent out-of-district. Coefficients are coloured grey if they are insignificant at $\alpha = 0.05$, red if they are significant with a negative effect, and green if they are significant with a positive effect. Reference entity is the district association, reference party is the Conservative Party, reference region is Ontario.

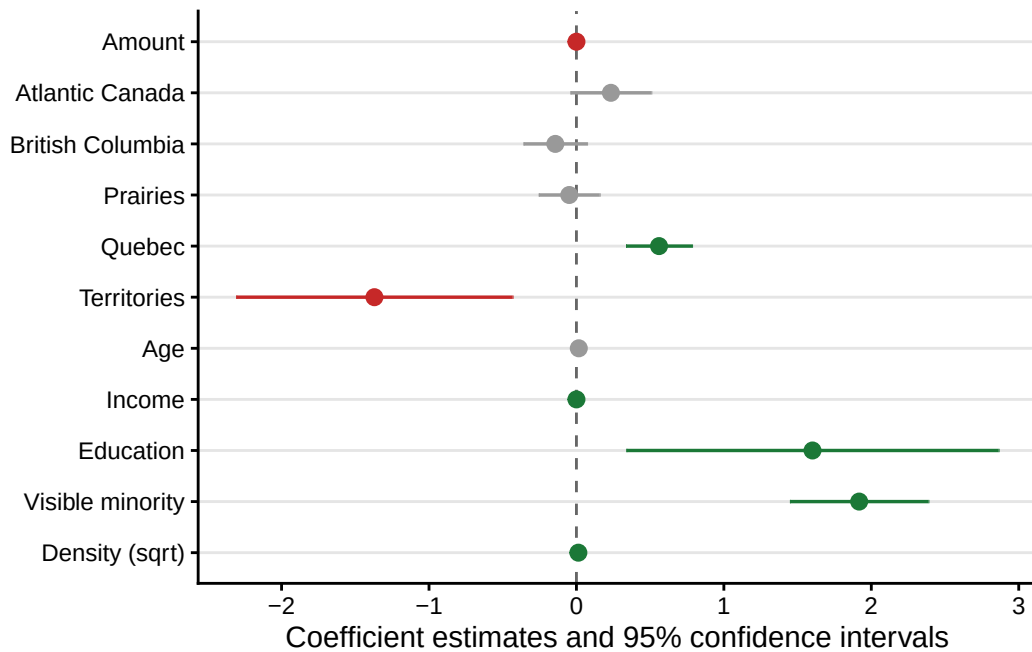


Figure 7: Coefficient estimates and 95% confidence intervals from a beta regression model where the outcome is the out-of-district share of the sum of contributions over \$200 originating from an individual district during our study period. Coefficients are coloured grey if they are insignificant at $\alpha = 0.05$, red if they are significant with a negative effect, and green if they are significant with a positive effect. Reference entity is the district association, reference party is the Conservative Party, reference region is Ontario.

5 Discussion

In this paper, we used open-source political financing data to document the extent, trends, and predictors of out-of-district donations to electoral candidates and district associations in Canada, from 2015 to 2024. Our findings are also contextualized within the broader scope of all²¹ Canadian federal political contributions over \$200 during this time (see Section 3.2.1). We present and discuss our major findings here below, along with some notable limitations to our study.

First, out-of-district contributions formed a persistent source of funding for electoral campaigns and district associations, the two primary players that are localized to districts. Naturally, overall contribution rates to these two political entities varied in time; campaign funding is largely restricted to writ periods, and district associations received nearly five times more contributions over \$200 during these periods than outside them. However, for both entities, the pooled share of funding received from outside their district (equivalently, the share of the total contributed amount that left its donor’s district) remained largely constant throughout the decade. Roughly 40% of individual donations over \$200 (representing 44% of the contributed sum) are sent out-of-district, a rate which remains representative throughout our study period. This rate and its consistency through time contrasts against U.S. findings, where the bulk of existing out-of-district donations research has been done. There, out-of-district funding shares to senators and congressional representatives during electoral campaigns have increased since the start of the 21st century (Gimpel et al. 2006; Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022), and the average representative in 2022 received around two-thirds of their contributions from out-of-district (Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022).

While out-of-district contribution rates varied little over time, across parties, and between recipient entity types (candidates or district associations), we document drastic differences in out-of-district propensity from district-to-district over our study period, both at the level of individual donations, and districts themselves. For example, out-of-district donation shares to district associations over the entire studied decade were as little as 5% for some districts, and as high as 75% in others. While we might expect passively higher out-of-district rates solely due to the spatial proximity of other districts, empirical variation in the rates of out-of-district giving far exceeded simulated expectations under this hypothesis. Further, most deviations from expected out-of-district donation rates were districts with higher, not lower observed out-of-district contribution shares.

²¹Excluding a small number of contributions (1.2%) that were not donor-geolocated.

Donations originating from densely populated, high-income, and well-educated districts are more likely to travel out-of-district, all else held constant. This set of covariates agrees with findings established in the U.S. (Gimpel et al. 2008). These are also significant predictors of donation rates in general, across North America (Gimpel et al. 2008; Garnett 2024). In addition to these, however, the visible minority proportion of a donor’s home environment is positively associated with out-of-district giving, and was the single most explanatory socio-demographic predictor in both of our models. This finding contrasts against the established profile of American “donor districts”, which historically have predominantly European ethnic makeups. However, recent Canadian studies support this finding. Garnett et al. (2022) among others note that some minority populations such as South Asians donate at rates that far exceed their share of the population, and, topically, Besco and Tolley (2022) find that donors from most minority ethnic groups show higher rates of out-of-district donation. While we cannot claim that donations from minority communities are from those minority groups themselves, the link between minority ethnicity and higher political participation is well-established in recent Canadian literature. We note also that present studies on this subject only consider donations to electoral candidates. We show that the pattern extends to district associations, and outside writ-periods.

Despite empirically high rates of out-of-district donation, we found that, to some extent, these donations remain a regionalized phenomenon. Nearly half of donations that leave their district during our study period were destined for entities in adjacent ones, and only around 12% ever even left their donor’s province (specifically, 9% for candidate-bound donations). U.S. research on out-of-district donations describes a highly nationalized funding regime among incumbent and campaigning House representatives (Gimpel et al. 2006; Canes-Wrone and Miller 2022; Keena 2024). Although incumbent politicians are outside the scope of this paper, our findings provide some evidence that candidate donor bases are largely formed within their own province. For those few donations bound for other provinces, we observe qualitatively different patterns for candidate-bound and district association-bound donations. Further research on Canadian out-of-district donations may take advantage of the network they form to explore these patterns further.

Our findings are accompanied by some important limitations. First, the donors of a non-negligible proportion (32%) of the full amount addressed to localized entities were under \$200, and therefore not included in our study. The majority (85%) of these donations were location-anonymized, and were excluded out of necessity. Distributional comparisons between study and location-anonymized contributions see Appendix D showed that this missing sum had similar distributions to the study data across factors such as recipient party, district, and entity, suggesting that their exclusion introduced little systematic bias into our study dataset.

However, location-disclosed contributions were differently distributed. To an overwhelming degree (95% of cases), these were in-district donations to Liberal district associations outside of election cycles, since location disclosure is optional under \$200. Given the specific nature of these donations, their exclusion likely only introduces bias to our estimates of out-of-district rates to Liberal district associations, which were found to receive the largest contribution share from out-of-district among all entity-party pairs (57% compared to the average of 40%).

Second, our focus on analyzing out-of-district contributions meant excluding donations addressed to national entities (parties and leadership contestants). As shown in Section 3.2, contributions of this type represented a majority (around 80%) of contributions during our study period. Although necessary given our study topic, these exclusions limit the generalizability of our study; the average Canadian donor cannot actually be assessed as an out-of-district or in-district giver.

Third, our chosen study period (October 2015 to April 2024) awkwardly truncates the available data in the middle of the period between the 44th and 45th general elections. This was done in an attempt to restrict our analysis to a single, static set of districts. While we succeeded in excluding non-2013-order districts, we cannot guarantee that all valid 2013-order FED entries were captured²², since the adoption of new districts is a multi-year project and timelines can differ drastically between locations ([Elections Canada 2025b](#)). Further, our chosen date range results in the third non-election period of our analysis being incomplete, so we cannot claim to have studied three full parliaments. However, we did not identify any systematic differences in out-of-district donation rates between interelection periods, having mainly identified differences through space, and not through time.

²²Over all entries in the dataset which had recipients belonging to 2013-order districts (2004 - present), only 0.5% were not captured by our chosen range.

Appendix

A Background on Canadian Political Financing

A.1 Individual Contribution Limits

The *Canada Elections Act* imposes individual contribution limits on donors seeking to contribute to one of the following registered, federal political entities²³: political parties, electoral district associations (EDAs), candidates, party nomination contestants, and party leadership contestants ([Elections Canada 2026a](#)). These limits are shown in Table 7²⁴ and Table 8. On top of these, candidates are also permitted to give an additional \$1,775 in total per year in contributions to other candidates, registered associations, or nomination contests, including their own. Regulated expenses for any of the entities themselves cannot exceed specific values, which are determined on an annual basis, and are different for each riding (see [Elections Canada 2026b](#)). Individual contributions to registered third-party organizations are not regulated by the *Act*, and were not included in this study ([Elections Canada 2026f](#)).

Only Canadian citizens or permanent residents can make contributions ([Elections Canada 2026f](#)). Any donor who contributed \$20 or more to any of the five federal political entities listed above must have their name recorded (but not reported to Elections Canada). Donors with contributions exceeding \$200 must also have their names and addresses recorded and reported to Elections Canada. Cash donations above \$20 are prohibited ([Elections Canada 2026f](#)).

A.2 Financial Reporting Requirements of Federal Political Entities

All of the information presented in this section can be found on the “Political Financing” page of the Elections Canada website ([Elections Canada 2026e](#)). Financial returns represent an account of an entity’s inflow (i.e. contributions, loans or transfers) and outflow (expenses). At minimum, all entities must submit financial returns annually (for parties and EDAs), or within 4 to 8 months after an electoral event (for parties, candidates, third parties, leadership contestants, and nomination contestants exceeding \$1000 in contributions or expenses). Returns with large transaction amounts must be accompanied by an external audit. Entities such as parties and EDAs may be required to file reports on a quarterly basis. Some (but not all) returns are

²³A full definition for each entity is available at Elections Canada ([2026d](#)).

²⁴Contribution limits presented here are only for 2026. They increase by \$25 every year on January 1st.

Table 7: 2026 Annual Limits on Individual Contributions, Loans, and Loan Guarantees (adapted from Elections Canada website).

Political Entity	2026 Annual Limit (CAD)
To each registered national party	\$1,775
In total, to all leadership contestants in a particular contest	\$1,775
In total, to all EDAs, nomination contestants, and candidates (for each registered party)	\$1,775
In total, to each independent or non-affiliated candidate	\$1,775

Table 8: 2026 Limits on Individual Contributions, Loans, and Loan Guarantees, for Politicians Contributing to Their Own Campaigns.

Politician	Own-Campaign Contribution Limit (CAD)
Nomination Contestant	\$1,000 (in addition to regular Annual limits)
Candidate	\$5,000
Leadership Contestant	\$25,000

reviewed by Elections Canada auditors. Risk-based auditing is used to determine which files will be audited and what level of audit will be performed ([Elections Canada 2026c](#)).

A.3 Electoral Redistricting

Electoral district boundaries are subject to change every 10 years, as required by the *Constitution of Canada* ([Elections Canada 2025b](#)). The 2013 representational order consisted of 338 districts, and the 2023 representational order consisted of 343 districts. The boundaries of existing districts are subject to change as well. The 2013 representational order was decidedly in effect between the calling of the 42nd general election on October 2, 2015, and the first dissolution of Parliament occurring after April 22, 2024 ([Elections Canada 2023](#)).

B Donations Data Pipeline

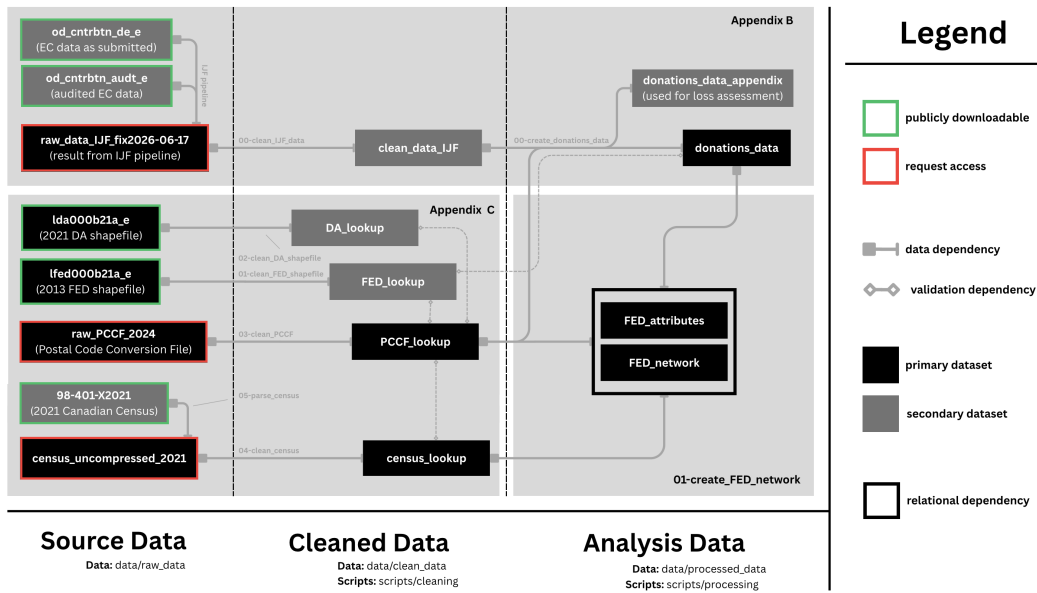


Figure 8: Flow diagram illustrating the full data pipeline used throughout this analysis. All scripts referenced in this figure can be accessed at <https://github.com/bennypk1/geolocating-political-donations>. This diagram was made using the Canva graphic design software.

In this section we provide a plain-language walkthrough of the three major cleaning and validation scripts used to transform contributions data from Elections Canada into the dataset used throughout our analysis. These scripts rely on other government datasets, cleaned

separately, documented in Appendix C. The full pipeline, including the steps described in Appendix C, is illustrated in Figure 8.

B.1 Investigative Journalism Foundation Pre-Cleaning

The original contribution datasets used in this study can be found on Elections Canada’s “Open data on contributions” page, under the heading “Data sets updated” ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). Two products are offered. The first is a dataset of contribution reports filed by all Canadian registered federal political entities see list of these in Appendix A.1 from January 2004 to present ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)). The second is an audited version of the first. Due to pre-screening policies and administrative lag, only some of the first dataset is audited. In our case, the audited version of the dataset has only 61.7% as many entries as the full un-audited data ($n = 10095198$; both accessed on May 5, 2026). Both datasets are updated on a weekly basis by Elections Canada ([Elections Canada 2025a](#)), as new audits and financial reports are filed.

Staff at the Investigative Journalism Foundation created a data pipeline to aggregate, de-duplicate, and clean these datasets. Both audited and un-audited versions of the same record were available for most records. To avoid duplicating these, audited and un-audited versions of the same record were linked by assuming that rows sharing the same donation date, electoral event, recipient, and recipient political party referred to the same entry. We note that this linkage approach carries the small risk that two distinct donations to the same recipient on the same date are incorrectly treated as duplicates. The pipeline preferentially keeps audited records when they are available.

Further de-duplication was effectuated differently based on the type of contribution being recorded. For loans, sums reported during an Annual filing might appear in a Quarterly report filed in the same year. In such cases, Annual records were preserved and Quarterly records were discarded. For all other types of contributions, only true duplicates (i.e. rows with identical entries identical in every field) were discarded. Additionally, some entries represented aggregated sums of contributions from anonymous donors. For these, Elections Canada reports a cumulative total per recipient Annually and Quarterly, meaning that the same aggregate sum could appear twice in the same year. To avoid double-counting these, only the largest reported aggregate sum per recipient per year was retained. Finally, a few smaller cleaning procedures were applied to the columns themselves; Table 9 shows where each of the columns present in the IJF data were drawn from columns at the source, and any notable procedures applied to them.

Table 9: Description of where the columns in the IJF data were derived from the source, and any cleaning procedures applied. Variables added for internal database consistency (e.g. processing dates) and redundant variables (e.g. donation year) are not shown here.

IJF Column	EC Source Column(s)	Notes
donor_full_name	Contributor name ; Contributor last name ; Contributor first name ; Contributor middle initial	Concatenated source columns, delimited by commas.
donor_type	Contributor type	No changes from source.
donor_location	Contributor City ; Contributor Province ; Contributor Postal code	Concatenated source columns, delimited by commas.
donation_date	Contribution Received date ; Fiscal/Election date	Used ‘Contribution Received date’ when available, filled with Fiscal/Election date oth- erwise. Flagged when impu- tation occurred. Removed in- valid dates.
electoral_event	Electoral event	Donations to leadership and nomination contestants had NA entries here. Otherwise, no changes from source.
amount_monetary	Monetary amount	No changes from source.
amount_non_monetary	Non-Monetary amount	No changes from source.
recipient	Recipient ; Recipient last name ; Recipient first name ; Recipient middle initial	Concatenated source columns, delimited by commas.
electoral_district	Electoral District	No changes from source.
political_entity	Political Entity	No changes from source.
political_party	Political Party of Recipient	No changes from source.

B.2 Initial Cleaning of IJF Data

We applied further cleaning and filtering steps to the data supplied by the Investigative Journalism Foundation. First, we removed redundant columns (e.g. data had columns `year` and `donation_year` which were identical for every entry) and columns used for internal consistency (e.g. the date the entry was added by the organization). Next, we removed entries with malformed dates, or disagreements between the year and date columns. Less than 0.001% of entries were discarded at this step, all corresponding to donations dated in later months of 2026. We then filtered for only donations stated to have been made by individuals. Less than 0.4% of the data was removed at this step, the overwhelming majority of which were records dated before 2006, outside the scope of our study. Next, we filtered for donations where the sum of monetary and non-monetary contributions was present and positive. Less than 0.02% of the data was removed at this step. We then removed entries where the donor or recipient name was either missing or shorter than 4 characters (after trimming whitespaces). Less than 0.001% of data was removed at this step, most of which also had missing donor locations. Finally, we removed individual donations with amounts larger than \$25000. Here we were careful to exclude entries that represented aggregated sums of anonymous contributions, which were flagged by searching for entries where `donor_full_name` started with “Contribut”. Less than 0.001% of the data was removed at this step. In total, 0.4% of entries ($n \sim 30,000$) were discarded in this section.

Donor postal codes were extracted from the `donor_location` column using regex-based string matching. Canadian postal codes always follow the format A0A0A0, where 0 is a digit and A is a letter (excluding I, O, D, F, Q, or U). Also, they may not start with W or Z ([Canada Post 2026](#)). These facts were used to verify the structure of extracted postal codes, and apply the following imputations:

- “O”s in a number slot were taken to mean “0”
- “I”s in a number slot were taken to mean “1”
- “!” in a number slot were taken to mean “1”

After imputations, we were able to recover 99.89% of individual donor postal codes. The remaining 0.11% were kept, with their postal codes set to NA. We note that while these postal codes are guaranteed to be structurally correct, we did not validate whether the codes matched their associated provinces, cities, or were actually used. The effective validity of these postal codes is verified in Appendix B.3. 0.35% of entries ($n \sim 26,000$) represented aggregated sums of anonymous contributions, and therefore did not have associated postal codes. Despite their scarcity, these amounted to 24.1% of the total contributed amount in the dataset. These were kept at this stage.

We also performed simple string cleaning procedures such as whitespace stripping and entity matching (e.g. United Party of Canada (UP) and United Party of Canada clearly refer to the same political party). Notably all donation recipients in the dataset had associated electoral districts (apart from leadership contestants and registered parties, since these are non-local entities) and political parties. Spot checking revealed no district or party attribution errors among a small set of recipients, however we could not completely confirm that recipient districts or parties were correct.

B.3 Clean IJF to donations_data

In this section we describe how our primary study dataset was derived from the cleaned IJF data, and augmented to include the donor’s district using a custom postal code conversion file (PCCF) described in Appendix C.1. The resulting dataset represents all donor-geolocated contributions above \$200 made out to federal political entities (excluding nomination contestants and candidates during by-elections).

First, we restricted the dataset to only those entries with donation dates between October 2, 2015, and April 22, 2024, capturing the effective period of the 2013 representational order see Appendix A.1. Next, we removed entries where the recipient’s district was not one of the 338 possible districts in the 2013 representational order, referencing our modified PCCF (0.002% of cases). Next, we removed entries where the reported electoral event did not happen within our date range (e.g. 39th general election was in 2006). Although it is possible that these were retroactively added for past events, less than 0.001% of the data had this issue, so their removal did not impact our analysis. Next, we removed individual donations addressed to localized entities which had amounts larger than what the contribution limits allowed (0.0001% of cases). For candidates this was \$5000, and for registered associations this was \$3550. Next, we removed donations addressed to leadership contestants for parties where no such contest occurred during our study period (0.0001% of cases). Nomination contestants were removed entirely, to simplify analysis. 3% of donations (7% of summed total) received during general election periods had receipt dates outside the stated period (usually dated after the writ period had ended, not before it started). These were not removed due to their non-trivial abundance, however many analyses and visualizations split the data into donations received during vs. outside writ periods. In those cases, these data are considered to have been received outside a writ period. All such anomalies originated from financial reports filed by electoral candidates.

As mentioned in the main text, our study considers only donations above \$200, since these are guaranteed to have recorded donor postal codes. This step discards 45% of the total contributed amount during our study period, but only 32% of the total amount received by

localized entities (i.e. candidates and district associations). These excluded data are discussed further in Appendix D. For the remaining entries, donor postal codes were matched to their corresponding census dissemination areas (DAs) and federal electoral districts (FEDs) using our modified PCCF file. 1.2% of donor postal codes (representing 1.3% of the total amount contributed) were either missing or could not be matched, and were dropped. Rates were 2.1% and 2.4% for localized entities. Figure 9 breaks down the discarded data by its cause, for localized entities (since these are the primary focus of our study). Finally, columns were renamed, merged, and variables were joined to improve the dataset’s usability. The resulting schema is shown in part in Table 10. We provide a list of notable operations here below:

- Monetary (99.8%) and non-monetary (0.2%) contributions were joined, and analysis was carried out on the total.
- Specific electoral events were grouped into the categories: Leadership contest, Nomination contest, General election, By-election, and Non-electoral (i.e. annual or quarterly filings).
- We added a variable to indicate during which writ period (if any) a donation was received, based on `donation_date`. Writ periods were taken to be August 2 to October 19 (2015), September 11 to October 21 (2019) and August 15 to September 20 (2021). By-elections are therefore not considered in the election vs. non-election period distinction, however they only account for 0.1% of the total contributed amount during the study period.

C Supplementary Datasets

In this section we describe how we created two custom lookup tables that the cleaning scripts in Appendix B rely on; one to convert between different levels of spatial hierarchy, and a second to retrieve specific socio-demographic statistics at the census dissemination area. Their place in the full pipeline is illustrated in Figure 8.

C.1 Spatial Lookup Table (PCCF_lookup on GitHub)

The purpose of the table constructed in this section is to provide unambiguous links between any administrative area of interest and another at a larger scale (e.g. postal code to district, dissemination area to province, etc.). This custom table is a version of Statistics Canada’s 2024 postal code conversion files (PCCF), modified to resolve many-to-many spatial overlaps between postal codes, dissemination areas (DAs), and electoral districts (FEDs). The PCCF we used provides linkages between all registered Canadian postal codes (accurate as of June 2024) and various administrative divisions, including the dissemination areas (DAs) of the 2021

Table 10: Primary variables used in our study, with examples and descriptions. Although not shown, additional information used such as census variables or geographic attributes of districts are easily retrieved by relating a donor’s dissemination area or district to custom-made lookup tables.

Variable	Example	Description
donor_name	Alexandra Lulka	Donor full name.
donor_dissemination_area	35202387	Dissemination area (UID) associated with donor postal code.
donor_district	Eglinton–Lawrence	Electoral district associated with donor postal code.
donation_date	2015-10-18	Date donation was received.
electoral_event	General Election	Electoral event (if any) occurring during donation.
total_amount	563.3	Summed monetary and non-monetary value of the donation, in CAD.
recipient_name	Joe Oliver	Recipient full name.
recipient_district	Eglinton–Lawrence	District of the recipient (if applicable).
political_entity	Candidates	Entity type of the recipient.
political_party	Conservative Party of Canada	Recipient party affiliation (if any).
is_out_of_district	FALSE	Whether donor and recipient districts are different.

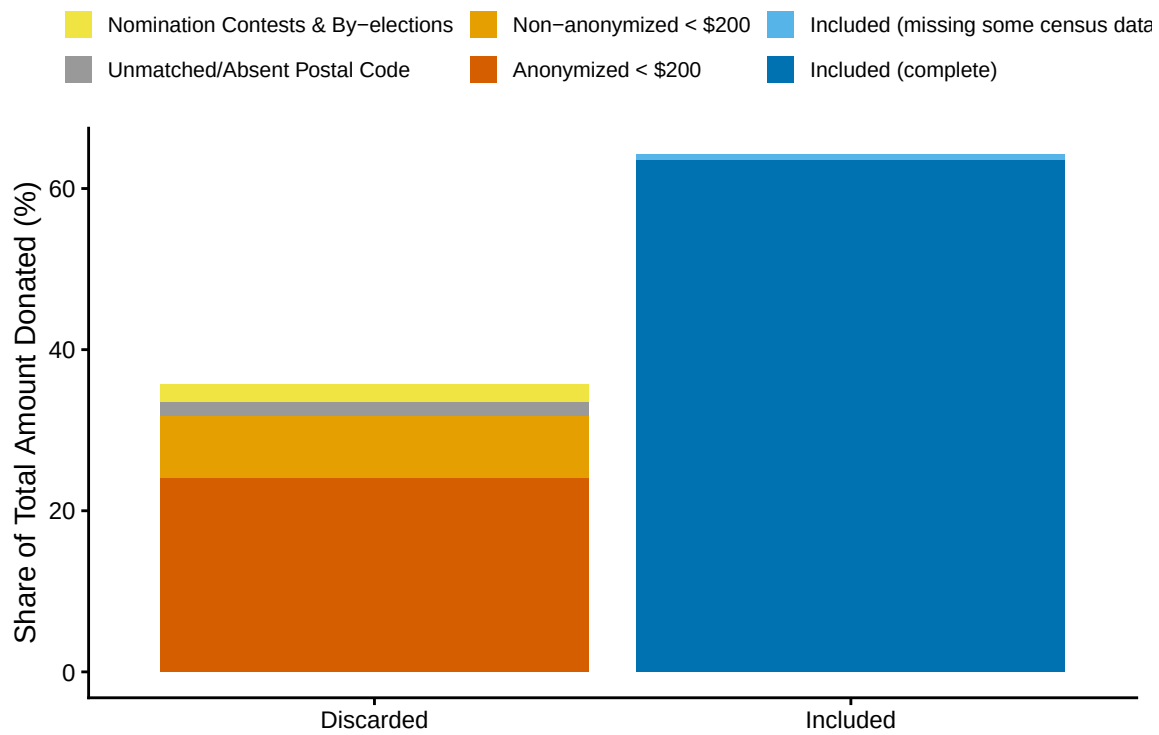


Figure 9: Total amount donated to localized entities (candidates and district associations) during our study period, split by whether or not the share was included in the study. The share of discarded contributions (left) is further broken down by the cause of its removal. We also display the share of included data to which not all census variables could be attributed (light blue).

Census, and the federal electoral districts (FEDs) of the 2013 representational order ([Statistics Canada 2025](#)). These sets of DAs and FEDs are the same versions we chose for our study. Access to this PCCF was granted to us by the University of Toronto. The result of this process is shown in part in Table 11.

To resolve cases where one postal code straddled multiple dissemination areas, we used a single link indicator (SLI) to establish a one-to-one relationship between postal codes and DAs, available in PCCF files by default ([Statistics Canada 2025](#)). Statistics Canada determines SLIs by estimating the population that resides in each DA within the postal code area (based on 2021 Census population counts) and assigns the code to the one with a higher population ([Statistics Canada 2025](#)). This procedure removed 35% of links present in the original PCCF, however no single postal code was removed from the file entirely. A small number of postal codes (0.7%) were removed for missing either an associated DA or FED. All postal codes had associated provinces. In addition, 1.6% of dissemination areas in the dataset straddled multiple district boundaries. To resolve this, for each overlap case, we (1) counted how many postal codes within the dissemination area linked to each candidate FED, and (2) assigned the entire DA, and all of its postal codes to the FED holding the plurality of those postal codes, discarding the postal codes that mapped to any minority FED. Ties between FEDs were broken deterministically by FED UID. This resolution step resulted in the loss of roughly 0.5% of postal codes. Applied to the contributions dataset used in this study, these resolutions increased the share of entries whose donor postal codes could not be matched to the PCCF from 0.7% to 1.2%.

As a final step, we ran a suite of tests, primarily to confirm that the resolved table formed a strictly nested hierarchy: each postal code mapped to a single DA, each DA or postal code to a single FED, and each FED, DA, or postal code to a single province. We also verified that every postal code appeared exactly once, and that they were correctly formatted following Canada Post’s guidelines ([Canada Post 2026](#)). We also confirmed that all DA and FED UIDs could be cross-referenced with Statistics Canada’s 2021 DA and 2013 FED shapefiles ([Statistics Canada 2022a](#)), and that all 338 districts and 13 provinces remained represented. Because of these tests, this spatial lookup table was treated as an authoritative list of valid postal codes, dissemination areas, districts, and provinces, which greatly simplified our analysis.

C.2 Census Lookup Table ([census_lookup](#) on GitHub)

The purpose of the table constructed in this section is to provide specific socio-demographic variables (listed in Table 12) for every dissemination area (DA) present in the spatial lookup table (described in Section C.1). Socio-demographic information at this spatial scale was

Table 11: Custom spatial lookup table, modified from Statistics Canada’s Postal Code Conversion File. This table unambiguously links each Canadian postal code to a 2021 census dissemination area, and each census dissemination area to a federal electoral district from the 2013 representational order. Only a sample of four entries are shown.

Postal Code	Dissemination Area	Federal Electoral District
M4P1E4	35202387	Eglinton–Lawrence
K1A0A6	35061205	Ottawa Centre
V6B1A1	59153201	Vancouver Centre
H3A0G4	24661048	Outremont

sourced from the 2021 Census, and specifically from the “Canada, provinces, territories, census divisions (CDs), census subdivisions (CSDs) and dissemination areas (DAs)” available for download online ([Statistics Canada 2022b](#)). We chose the 2021 Census over the 2016 Census since the midpoint of our time period (2019) is closer to 2021 than 2016. We chose the dissemination area, an administrative region that houses roughly 400 to 700 people, since it is the smallest spatial scale where each of our desired statistics are recorded ([Statistics Canada 2021](#)). All DAs listed in our spatial lookup file see Appendix C.1 were present in the Census dataset we used. Since these DAs are the only ones we would ever use for analysis, the other 15.1% of DAs were dropped.

3.2% of remaining DAs were missing at least one census variable: 0.05% were missing all demographic variables, 0.43% only had population, area, and density, 0.12% were only missing the 25% sampled variables (i.e. ethnicity and education level), and 2.62% had all variables recorded except household income. Notably, all entries’ missingness could be grouped into five strictly hierarchical stages, summarized in Table 13. Entries with missing variables were not dropped, but were instead flagged so that they could be easily identified during analysis. We also converted ethnicity and education counts to proportions. Table 14 provides a glimpse of the resulting Census dataset.

Table 12: Census IDs, descriptions, and sample sizes for each census variable used in this study. Variables with a 25% sample size were recorded for only 25% of the population, to preserve privacy.

Characteristic ID	Description	Sample Size
1	Population, 2021	100%
6	Population density (per square kilometres)	100%
7	Land area (square kilometres)	100%
39	Average (mean) age	100%
243	Median household income (total, in 2020)	100%
1683	Total population in private households	25%
1684	Total visible minority population	25%
1685	Total South Asian population	25%
1686	Total Chinese population	25%
1687	Total Black population	25%
1688	Total Filipino population	25%
1689	Total Arab population	25%
1690	Total Latin American population	25%
1691	Total Southeast Asian population	25%
1692	Total West Asian population	25%
1693	Total Korean population	25%
1694	Total Japanese population	25%
1998	Total population aged 15+	25%
2001	Total population with a postsecondary certificate	25%

Table 13: Structure of missing Census data. Missingness is hierarchical in the Census dataset: entries at a higher stage of missingness are always missing everything in the lower stages.

Missing Stage	Count	% of Total
0. Complete	47593	96.78%
1. Missing Median Household Income	1288	2.62%
2. Missing 25% Sample Variables	57	0.12%
3. Missing Age	211	0.43%
4. Missing Population	26	0.05%

Table 14: Custom census lookup table. This table provides desired socio-demographic information for every dissemination area in the 2021 Census. Only a sample of four entries are shown. Only population, density, and median household income are shown.

Dissemination Area (UID)	Population	Density (per sqkm)	Median Household Income (CAD)
35202387	612	4381.2	\$98,500
35061205	548	3920.7	\$87,200
59153201	701	6210.5	\$76,300
24661048	489	5104.9	\$92,100

D Contributions Under \$200

E Testing Whether Out-of-District Rates can be Explained by Distance Alone

E.1 Simulation Setup

Figure 3 showcases how variable out-of-district donation rates are at the district level. However, this may simply be a byproduct of the spatial arrangement of electoral districts. Districts vary enormously in size, from the 13 square kilometres that make up Toronto–St. Paul, to the entire province of Nunavut. Assuming that social influence decays as a function of distance, we should expect a donor residing in a district in downtown Toronto to (1) be more aware of or (2) perceive to have a greater stake in district associations and candidates outside their own district, simply by virtue of their spatial proximity. By contrast, a donor in Nunavut may be expected to place less importance on political entities in the neighbouring Northwest Territories, whose population centre is nearly one thousand kilometres away. In this section we design and execute a simulation to test the null hypothesis that the observed variance in district-level out-of-district donation rates is well-explained by differences in spatial clustering.

- Assign a random distance to each donation.
- If this distance is $< 1\text{km}$, immediately declare the donation as having been received in-district. Otherwise, continue.
- Assign a random direction for that donation.
- Determine if it landed within Canada. If it didn't choose a different direction. Otherwise, continue.
- Determine which district it landed in.
- Declare in-district vs. out-of-district.

Distances were assigned by sampling from the true distance distribution of the observed donations dataset, shown in Figure 10 (we note that this figure only shows out-of-district donations; the majority of donations were in-district, and therefore travelled zero kilometres). The distance a donation travelled was defined to be zero if the donation was in-district, and otherwise set to be the spatial distance between the centroid of the donor's dissemination area, and the centroid of the recipient's district. Shapefiles were used to determine which district a randomly travelling donation landed in.

For each district, 30 replicate simulations were run to estimate the sample distribution of the simulation. Using these distributions, the observed out-of-district proportions were compared

with the simulated out-of-district proportions, for each district. Only results for the count of out-of-district donors (not the amount of donations sent out-of-district) was considered, however results were very similar for amounts, just with systematically wider sampling distributions.

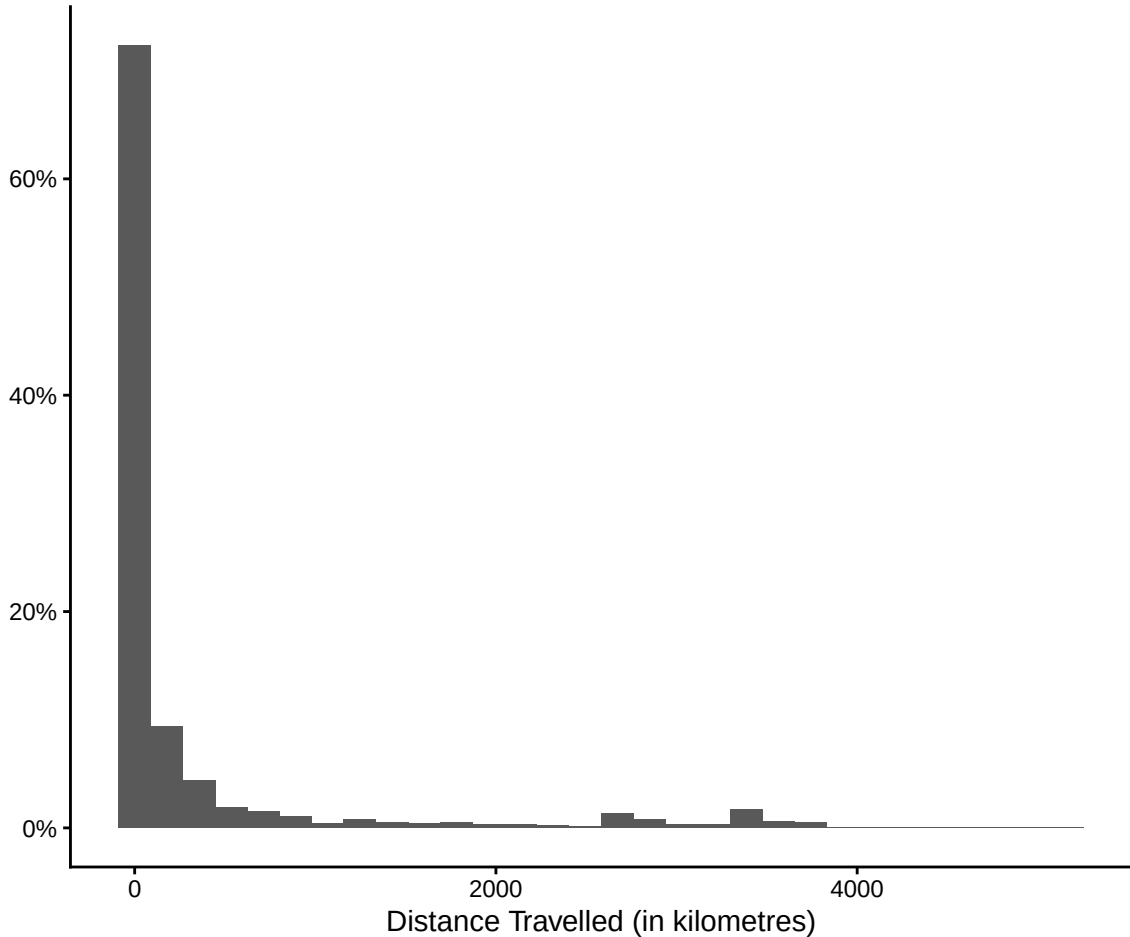


Figure 10: Distribution of donation distances for out-of-district donations over \$200 during our study period. Both donations to candidates and district associations are shown together, however distributions were very similar for both entities separately. Distance is measured as the distance from the donor dissemination area’s centroid to the recipient district’s centroid.

E.2 Simulation Results

When considering donations addressed to candidates (aggregated over all three election periods), only 6.5% of districts fell within the expected proportion of out-of-district donations. For donations addressed to EDAs over the entire study period, only 5.3% of districts fell within the expected proportion of out-of-district donations. Proportions of districts that fell within

their expected ranges were slightly higher (8.2% and 8.5% respectively) when looking at the share of the total contributed amount, however this was likely due to the systematically wider sampling distributions caused by the added variance incurred when using amounts.

Figure 11 shows that, for both entities, most districts have out-of-district proportions that deviate drastically from simulated expectations under the null hypothesis. Further, most deviations, including the largest ones in magnitude, were districts where the observed out-of-district donation rate was larger than expected, as opposed to smaller. This indicates that most districts have higher out-of-district donation rates than what can be explained by the spatial arrangement of districts alone. This can be seen more clearly in Figure 12; in both cases, much of the support for the observed distribution lies strictly above the support for the expected distribution. This skew in deviations is especially noticeable for donations addressed to district associations. Results using amount-weighted proportions were similar in both cases.

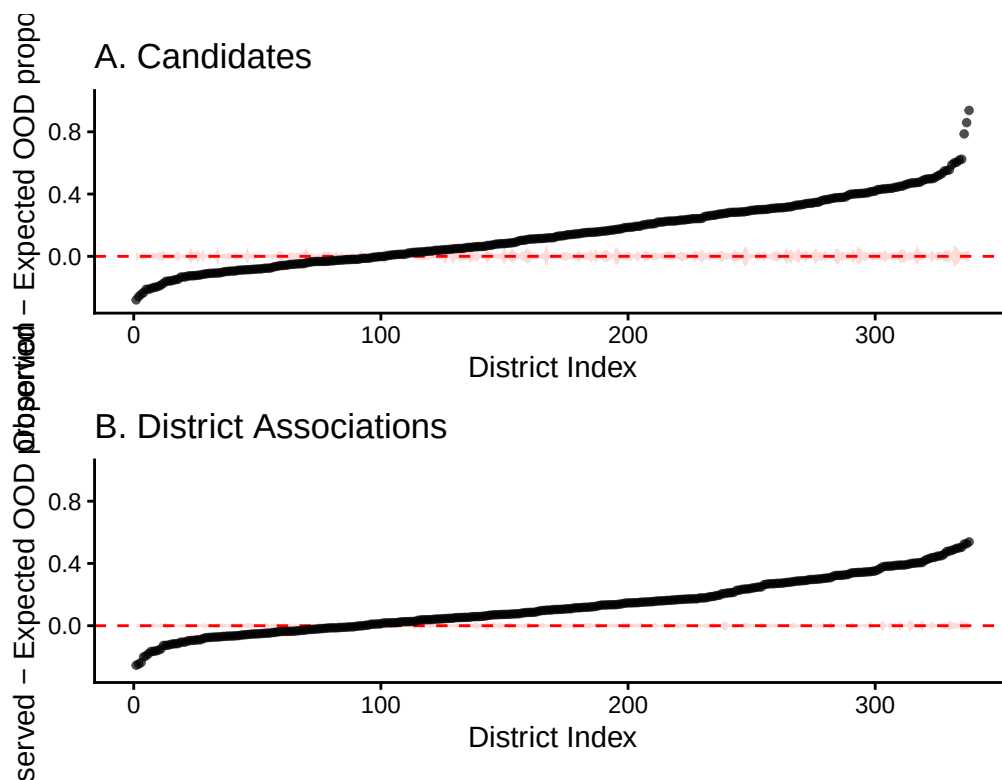


Figure 11: Deviation of each district’s observed proportion of out-of-district (OOD) donations from its simulated proportion under the null hypothesis. Results for both donations to candidates (A) and district associations (B) are shown. Districts are sorted by the sign and magnitude of their deviation. The dashed red line indicates no deviation, and the shaded red band gives the simulated 95% confidence interval. Points outside the band deviate more than spatial clustering alone can explain.

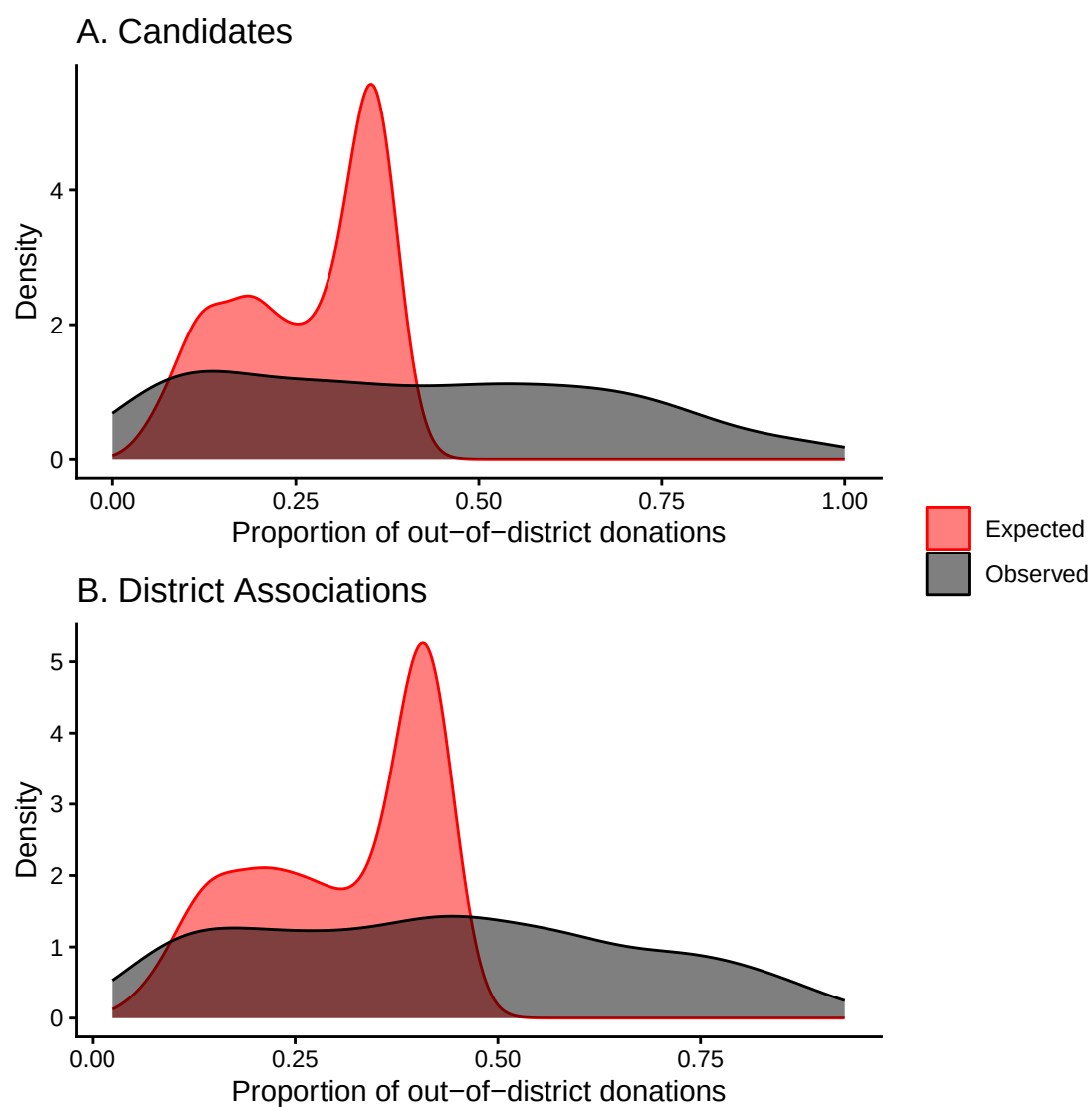


Figure 12: Distribution across districts of the observed (black) and simulated null-expected (red) proportion of out-of-district donations. Both donations to candidates (A) and district associations (B) are shown.

Table 15: Summaries of financial contributions to federal political entities over \$200 from 2015 to 2024, separated by entity. Only donations stated to have been received during a general election period are shown. Contributions received by nomination contestants are not shown.

Political Entity	Type	Donation Count	Donation Amount (Thousands)	Share of Total Amount
Candidate	Localized	29,380	\$18,872	25.7%
District Association	Localized	36,489	\$20,373	27.7%
Leadership Contestant	National	134	\$103	0.1%
Party	National	79,052	\$34,071	46.4%

F Additional Data Summaries

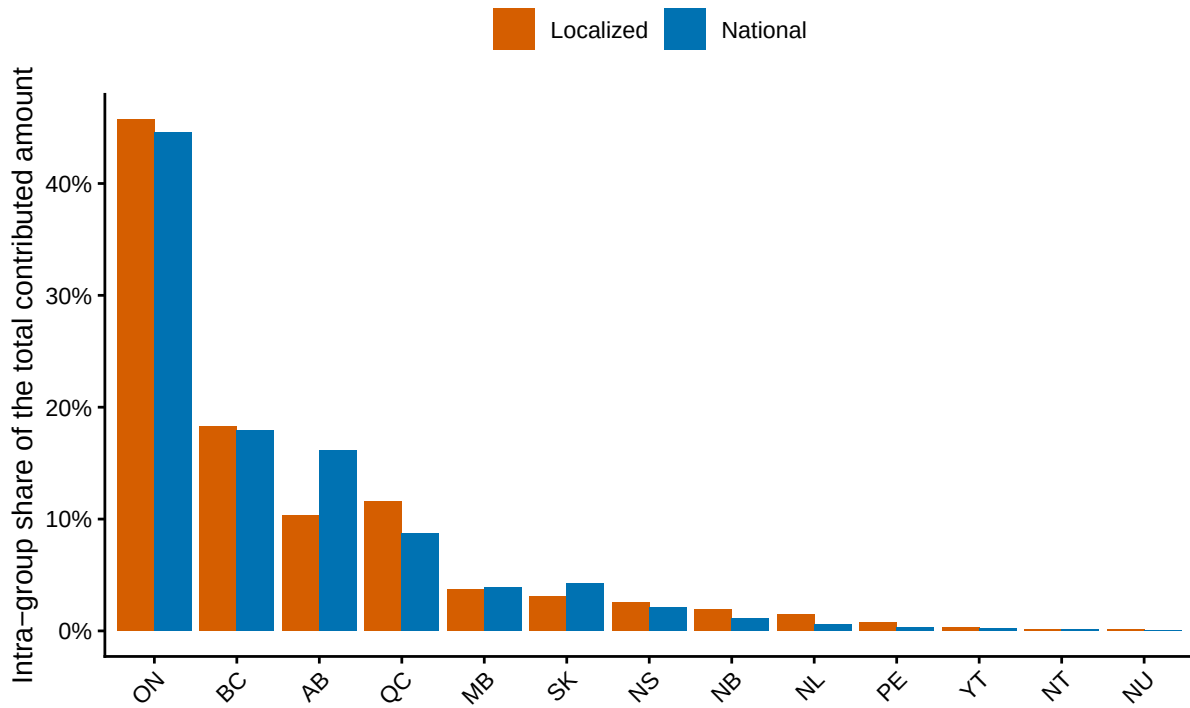


Figure 13: Distribution of contributions across donor provinces, shown separately for localized entities (candidates and district associations) and national ones (parties and leadership contestants). Within each group, bars give each province's share of that group's total contributed amount, and sum to 100% across provinces. Contributions over \$200 received from 2015 to 2024.

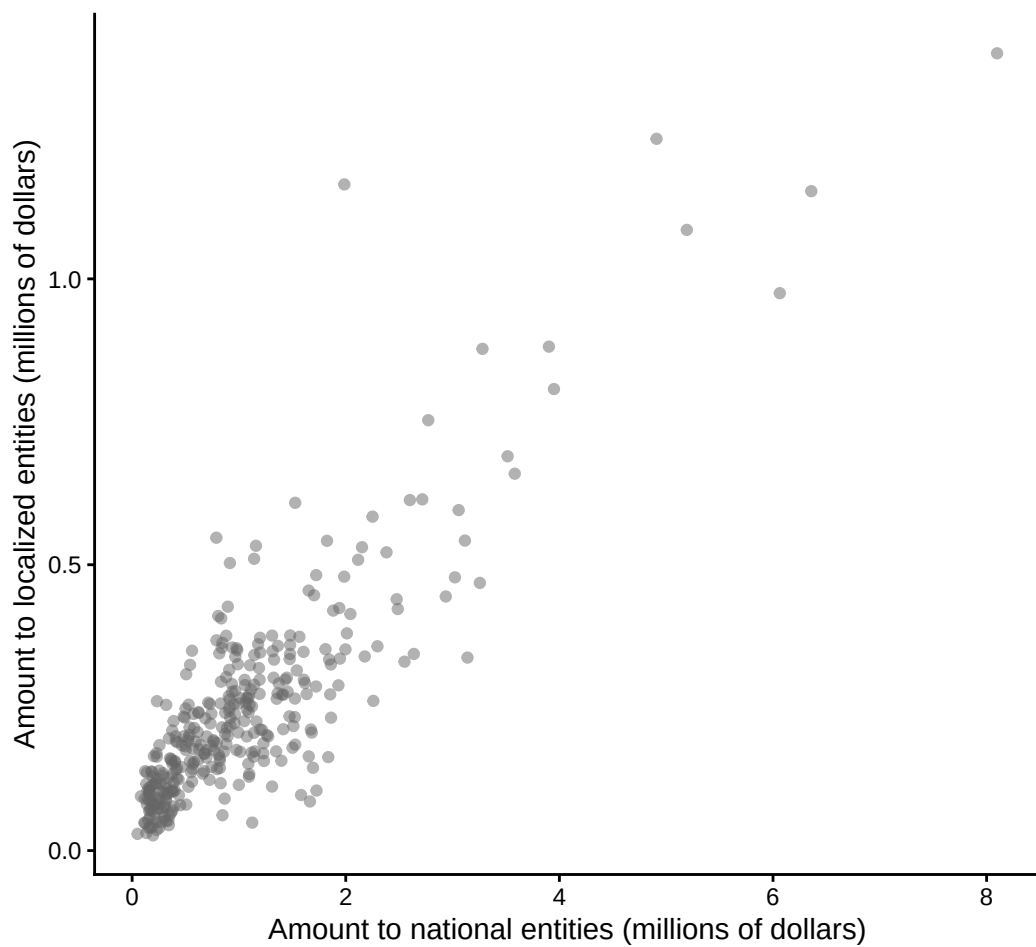
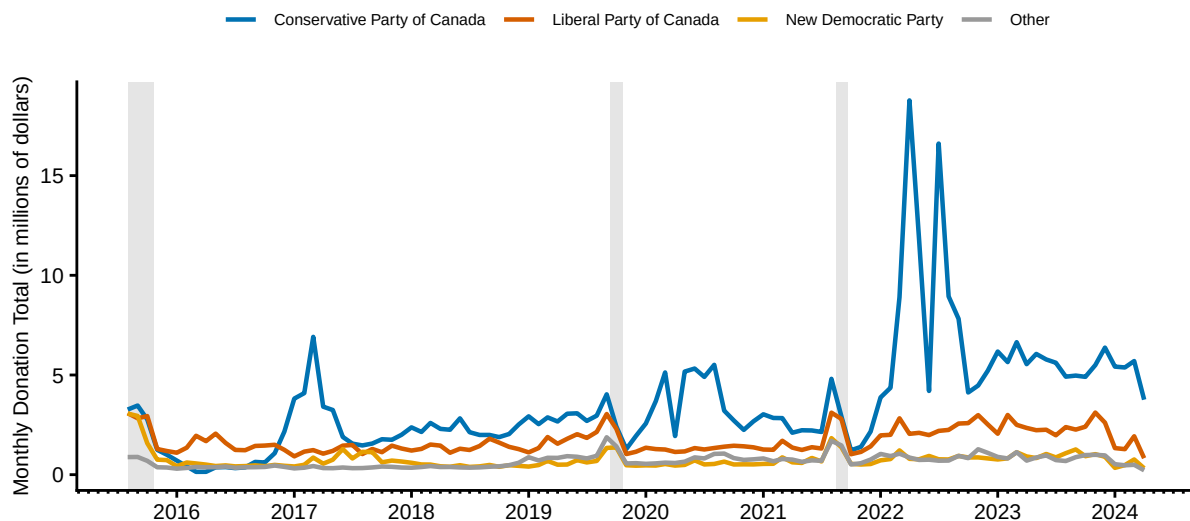


Figure 14: Total amount contributed to localized entities (candidates and district associations) against the total contributed to national entities (parties and leadership contestants), with one point per donor district. Contributions over \$200 received from 2015 to 2024.

A. National entities



B. Localized entities

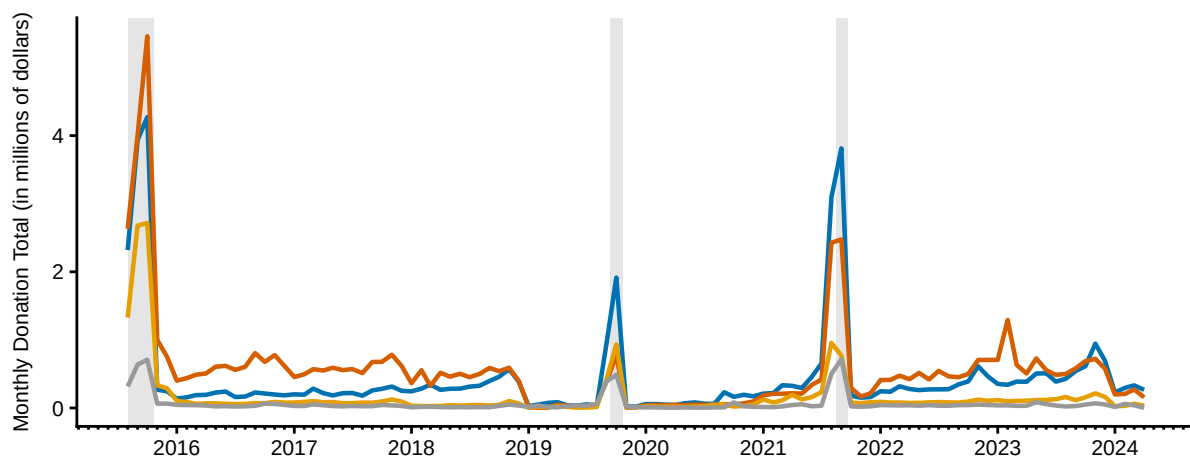


Figure 15: Timeline of all financial contributions to federal political entities (including those under \$200), from 2015 to 2024. (A) shows only contributions to national entities (parties and leadership contestants), and (B) shows only contributions to localized entities (candidates, nomination contestants, and district associations). Within each panel, trendlines are separated by the party of the recipient. Shaded vertical bars indicate the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th general election periods respectively.

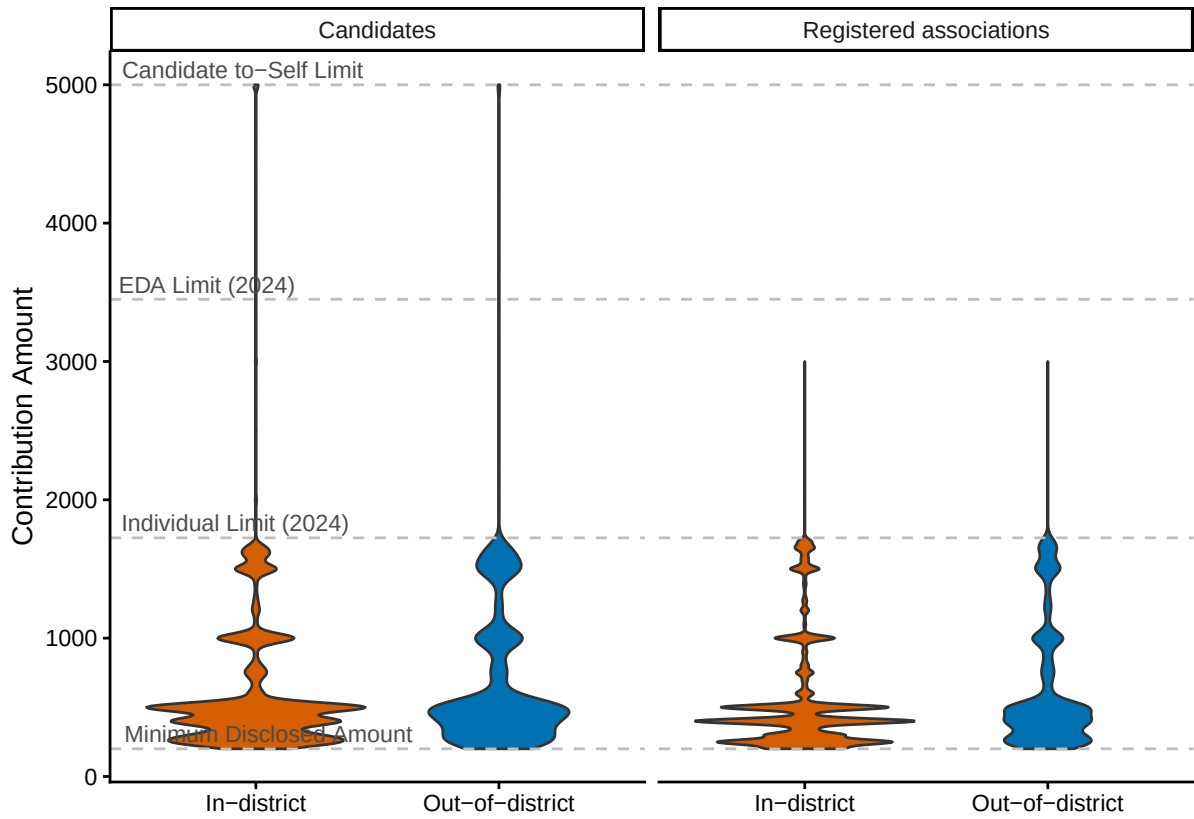


Figure 16: Value distributions of in- (blue) and out-of-district (red) contributions over \$200 received by candidates (left) and district associations (right) from 2015 to 2024. Dashed grey lines mark notable individual contribution limits.

Table 16: Proportion of contributions over \$200 that were received by localized entities (candidates and district associations) outside the donor’s district, from 2015 to 2024, broken down by recipient entity and party. The three largest parties are shown individually; all others are grouped into ‘Other’. Raw and value-weighted proportions of out-of-district donations (OOD) are reported, alongside overall contribution counts for reference. Contributions received by candidates outside general election cycles are not included in calculations.

Entity	Party	Donation Count	OOD Proportion	OOD Proportion (Amount Weighted)
Candidate	Conservative Party of Canada	14,421	36.1%	38.5%
Candidate	Liberal Party of Canada	5,961	39.7%	43.9%
Candidate	New Democratic Party	6,637	35.9%	39.6%
Candidate	Other	3,540	43.3%	41.4%
District Association	Conservative Party of Canada	38,756	36.0%	40.1%
District Association	Liberal Party of Canada	49,859	53.5%	57.8%
District Association	New Democratic Party	16,164	35.2%	35.8%
District Association	Other	3,840	34.6%	36.0%

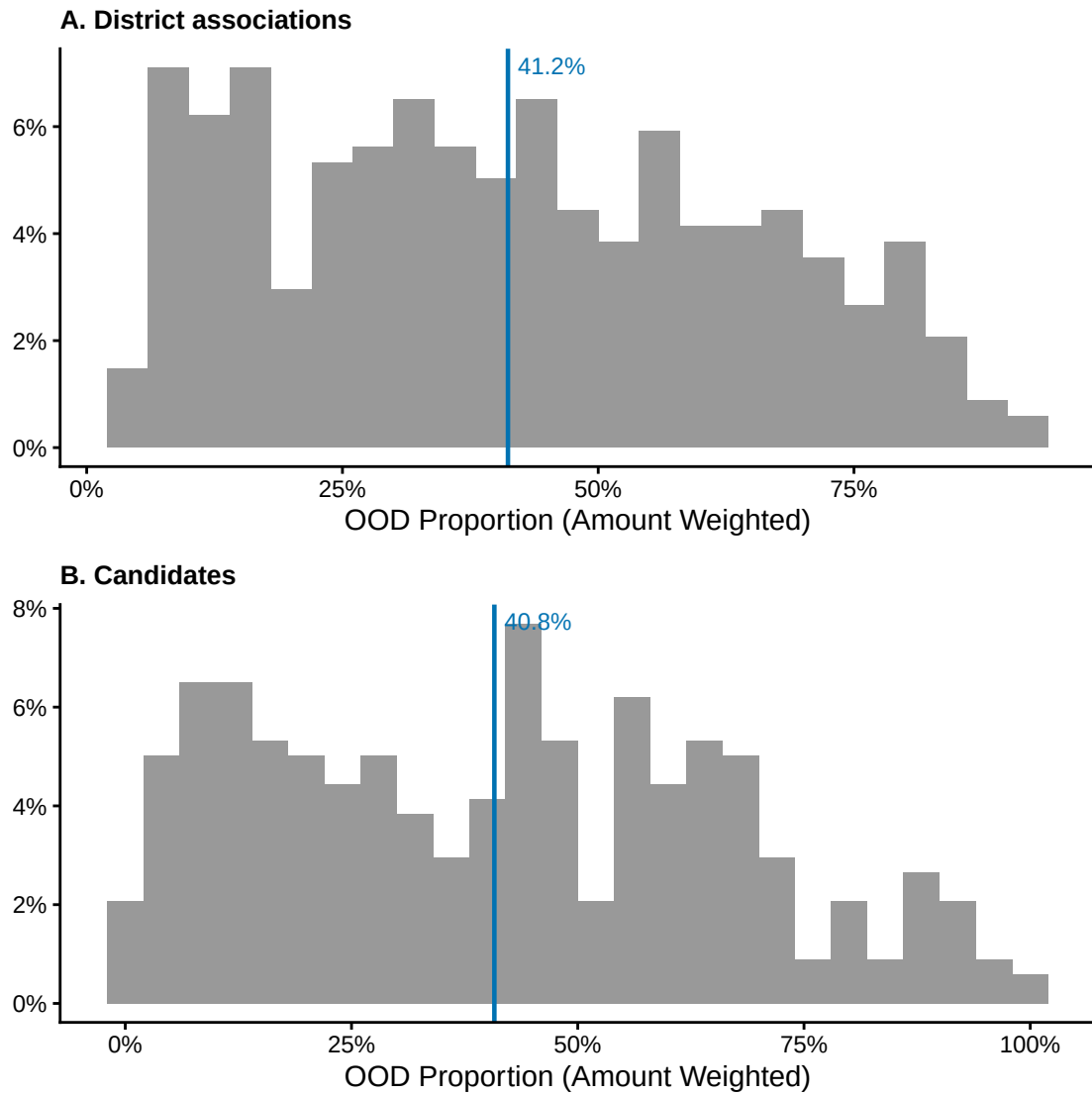


Figure 17: Distribution of out-of-district (OOD) contribution shares for each district in our study (for contributions over \$200, from 2015 to 2024). (A) and (B) show this distribution for donations to district associations and candidates separately. The district-level mean is indicated with an orange vertical line in each case. Distributions were similar when raw instead of amount-weighted proportions were used.

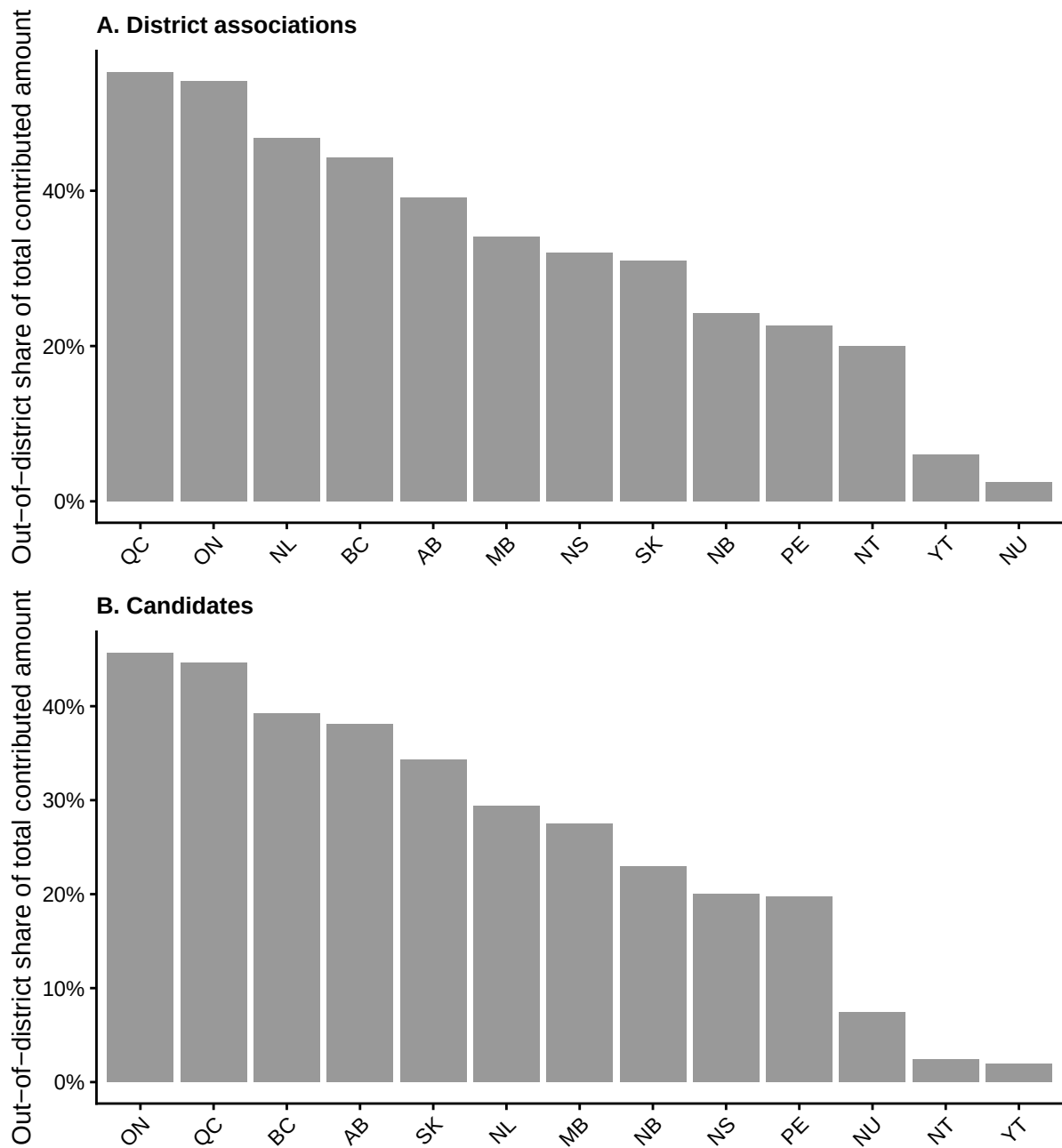


Figure 18: Out-of-district share of the total amount contributed over \$200 to (A) district associations and (B) candidates, for each donor province, from 2015 to 2024. Within each panel, provinces are ordered from highest to lowest out-of-district share.

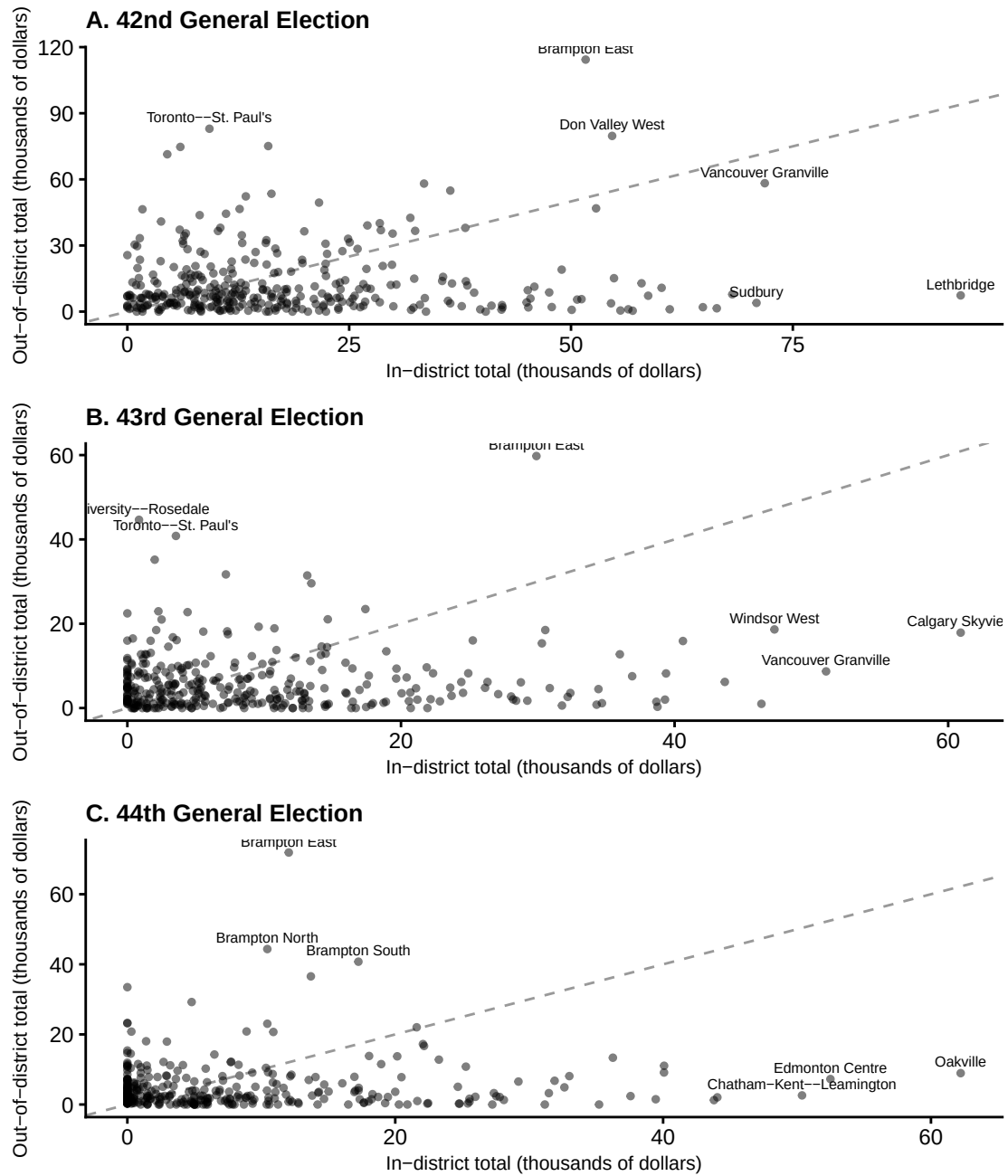


Figure 19: Relationship between the sum of contributions over \$200 donated in- v.s. out-of-district, for each district during the 2013 representational order (effective between 2015 and 2024). (A), (B), and (C) display this relationship for donations to candidates during the 42nd, 43rd, and 44th writ periods respectively. Points represent individual districts. The grey dashed line is 1:1. The top 3 districts by amount contributed in- and out-of-district respectively are labelled with their names.

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